BREADWINNING NORMS: EXPERIMENTAL EVIDENCE FROM INDIA*

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Abstract

How important are social norms in shaping women's labor supply relative to neoclassical economic forces? The widely studied "breadwinning norm" holds that it is socially undesirable for married women to earn more than their husbands. We test this idea in a field experiment by partnering with a large vocational training provider in India. We randomly vary wage offers for long-term salaried jobs among married women who graduated from the vocational training program. If the norm binds, labor supply should be discontinuous or flatten when women are offered wages above their husbands' income. We find no evidence that women reduce their labor supply when wage offers exceed their husbands' income and can reject a negative discontinuity as small as 3.3 percentage points. Instead, labor supply is highly responsive to wages, consistent with standard economic models. These findings hold even in households with the most restrictive gender attitudes or where husbands earn a fixed salary that can be easily compared to their wives'. Our results suggest that, even in the most conservative contexts, wages remain an important determinant of women's labor supply.

Keywords: social norms, breadwinning, gender, female labor supply, India
JEL codes: C93, D9, J12, J16, J22, O12, Z13

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1 Introduction

Despite decades of policy intervention, women work less than men in almost every country in the world. While standard economic models emphasize wages as the primary driver of labor market decisions (Killingsworth and Heckman, 1986; Cahuc, Carcillo and Zylberberg, 2014), a growing literature highlights the role of social norms, particularly those operating within the household, in shaping women's labor supply (Bursztyn, González and Yanagizawa-Drott, 2020; Jayachandran, 2021). Empirically evaluating the importance of norms relative to market incentives is critical to closing these gender gaps because the two explanations carry fundamentally different policy implications.

One norm that sharply captures this tension between economic and social forces is the breadwinning norm—the idea that a wife should not outearn her husband. Research in sociology and economics has long argued that this norm could generate large welfare losses, including increasing divorce rates and distorting home production (Heckert, Nowak and Snyder, 1998; Lippmann, Georgieff and Senik, 2020; Syrda, 2023). Most important are its implications for labor markets—if the norm binds, high-potential women may work fewer hours, enter lower-paying jobs, or even exit the labor market to avoid outearning their husbands. In their seminal work, Bertrand, Kamenica and Pan (2015) document a pattern consistent with this in the US: a large share of married women earn slightly less than their husbands, while strikingly few earn slightly more.[1] While this result has now been replicated in dozens of countries, including India (Grow and Van Bavel, 2020; Muñoz, Sansone and Tampellini, 2025; Sharma, 2026), there is ongoing debate as to whether this reflects breadwinning norms. Tests based on cross-sectional earnings distributions are plagued by confounds, as the same patterns are also consistent with other explanations, including income misreporting, marriage market matching, and coworking couples (Slotwinski and Roth, 2020; Zinovyeva and Tverdostup, 2021; Binder and Lam, 2022).[2] A sharper test would instead estimate labor

[1] Bertrand, Kamenica and Pan (2015) also provide additional observational evidence of the norm affecting labor supply, as well as marriage formation, marital satisfaction, and home production.

[2] Similarly, the absence of a discontinuity does not rule out the norm binding. The norm could also

supply directly: while standard models predict a smooth, upward-sloping curve, a theory of breadwinning norms predicts a discontinuous drop in labor supply, or a change in its elasticity, as a woman's potential earnings exceed her husband's.

Though tracing out labor supply provides a more direct test for the norm, implementing it poses several empirical challenges. First, isolating labor supply requires exogenous variation in women's wages that leaves their husbands' wages unchanged. Such variation is rare: most shocks, such as trade or local labor demand shocks, move both partners' wages and shift broader economic conditions. Second, because regression discontinuity designs are statistically demanding (Cook, 2008; Schochet, 2009), a well-powered test for breadwinning norms requires thousands of observed job choices with wage offers clustered near the husbands' incomes. Finally, for external validity, it is important to study women's choices over long-term jobs in an existing labor market. Long-term jobs make complying with the norm costly, while an existing labor market ensures couples face the same kinds of jobs and income comparisons they would encounter in the broader economy.

In this paper, we conduct the first field experiment testing whether breadwinning norms constrain married women's employment. We address the challenges detailed above by partnering with a large vocational training provider in India and randomizing the posted wages of long-term jobs offered to female graduates of its program (N=5,345 job choices). India provides an ideal setting to test for the norm. In addition to its widespread conservative gender attitudes (Jayachandran, 2015, 2021; Bursztyn et al., 2023), the cross-sectional patterns that motivated this literature are at their most extreme in India, where the drop in the share of married women earning just above their husbands is far larger than in the US (Gupta, 2022). Breadwinning norms are also of particular concern in developing economies such as India, where low female labor force participation has been linked to misallocation

produce a change in the elasticity of labor supply around the husband's income, suppressing women's labor supply without producing a discontinuity in realized earnings. For example, if a husband's unease grows the more his wife outearns him, the wife's labor supply may flatten or even slope downward as the offered wage crosses his income. These more subtle changes are difficult to detect using cross-sectional income distributions.

of labor and may be a significant impediment to growth (Hsieh et al., 2019; Ashraf et al., 2024).

We implement the experiment in partnership with one of India's largest NGOs, the Pratham Education Foundation, which has provided training and job placement services to more than 300,000 young adults across the country. Pratham's program consists of two months of vocational training followed by placement services, in which staff match graduates to jobs based on current availability and trainee preferences. The job placement process is particularly high stakes for trainees because it allows them to draw on Pratham's relationships with local employers. As a result, most graduates who complete the program find their first job through the placement process. To recruit women into the study, we contacted past graduates from eight healthcare training centers and offered them additional placement opportunities. Healthcare jobs are long-term and pay a fixed salary, which reduces concerns about income fluctuations and makes comparisons to husbands' incomes straightforward.[3] One hundred seventy-one eligible graduates completed the placement process, allowing us to observe their labor supply over real jobs in a familiar and natural setting.

We embedded a job application experiment into the placement process to generate exogenous wage variation over thousands of job choices. During an initial survey, we asked husbands to state their income in the presence of their wives, creating a common reference point for the household before presenting any job choices. We then presented women with 40 jobs, one at a time, and asked which they would apply to. Because these jobs were long-term, randomizing the wages they would receive was neither ethically nor logistically feasible. Instead, we truthfully told women that some of the jobs were real and some were hypothetical and then randomized the wages of the hypothetical jobs as a function of their husband's income.[4] Since we did not reveal which of the jobs were real, every choice was in

[3]It is not possible to adjust wages by working fewer or greater hours in the healthcare jobs we offer. Furthermore, all the jobs we offer are full-time, so the job offers would be difficult to supplement with additional work. The jobs are middle-income by Indian standards, with the median real job offered in the experiment paying at the 64th percentile of the national income distribution for women working full time. More than 80% of Pratham graduates remain in their jobs beyond six months of starting.

[4]To ensure the wage offers appear realistic, we pre-registered dropping women for whom half of the

expectation a high-stakes labor market decision. To maximize power for detecting a discontinuity, we oversampled offers near the husband's income. We matched women to jobs using an incentive-compatible mechanism. Women who applied and were matched to a job were charged a placement fee of 150 rupees ($7.5 PPP), so they were incentivized to only apply for jobs they would accept.[5] After making their initial application decisions, we gave them several days to discuss their choices with their husbands and family before finalizing them.[6] By observing women's final job application decisions at randomized wages, we can trace out their labor supply curve.

We begin by documenting descriptive patterns that suggest our sample is well suited to testing for the norm. First, our sample is middle-income and holds conservative gender attitudes. The median couple in our experiment sits at the 58th percentile of the national income distribution, and 30% of women report that a wife outearning her husband would create problems, in line with the national average.[7] Second, all working women say that their husbands know exactly how much they earn, thus ensuring couples are in a position to compare incomes. Finally, our experimental sample shows remarkably similar patterns in the cross-section to previous observational studies in India and elsewhere: among couples where both members were already working before the experiment, a significant share of married women earn weakly less than their husbands, while few outearn them.

In stark contrast to the cross-section, our experimental results show no evidence that breadwinning norms constrain women's labor market choices. Instead, labor supply rises strongly with wages, as standard economic models predict. A 1% increase in wages raised labor supply by 1.7%. In our pre-registered main specification, we detect no discontinuity

husband's wage is more than the highest real job wage, or four times the husband's wage is less than the lowest real job wage (at a given vocational training center). In robustness checks, we also drop women for whom the husband's wage is more than the highest real job wage, or less than the lowest real job wage and find similar results.

[5]The placement fee is approximately a quarter of the median couple's total daily wages.

[6]97% of women report discussing the jobs with their family before finalizing their applications.

[7]In the 2012 World Values Survey (WVS), 34% of individuals in India agreed that if a woman earns more money than her husband, it's almost certain to cause problems. Our sample is considerably more conservative than US populations, where only 12% agree with the statement (Inglehart et al., 2014).

in labor supply at the husband's income, and we can reject negative discontinuities as small as 3.3 percentage points. These patterns hold for women's initial application choices as well as their final choices after having spoken with their family and are robust to alternative regression discontinuity bandwidths.

The null holds even where one would expect the norm to bind most strongly. Given the importance of spousal communication in similar settings (Conlon et al., 2021; Lowe and McKelway, 2026), we randomly sent some women's initial choices to their husbands to ensure husbands were perfectly informed. We find no discontinuity in this group. Nor do we find one among households most likely to hold the norm: women who practice purdah (veiling), women who agree that a wife outearning her husband would cause problems, women who report having more conservative peers, and couples in which the husband earns a fixed salary, making it easier for the couple to compare incomes.

We also test for weaker forms of the norm. A discontinuity in labor supply is a demanding test, requiring the couple to precisely control their incomes and to incur a large cost the moment the wife's income exceeds her husband's. If the couple cannot perfectly control their incomes, one may instead expect a negative slope in labor supply around the husband's income. Across several pre-registered bandwidths, we instead find statistically significant *positive* slope estimates. Similarly, if the cost of violating the norm grows the more a wife outearns her husband, one may observe a change in the slope of labor supply. We find no such change. Across all specifications, subsamples, and forms of the norm we test, labor supply rises with wages as standard models predict, with no evidence of breadwinning norms.

To assess generalizability, we complement our experimental analysis with nationally representative panel data from the Consumer Pyramids Household Survey (CPHS). We test whether women who earn marginally more than their husbands are subsequently more likely to leave the labor market. This analysis also helps allay concerns that breadwinning norms bind only after a wife has accepted a job. Outearning one's husband does not predict exiting the labor market. We estimate precise nulls and can rule out reductions in labor supply as

small as 2.3 percentage points from outearning one's husband.

Finally, to reconcile our experimental results with the cross-sectional earnings distribution, we ask whether factors unrelated to labor supply could *plausibly* account for the discontinuity in the cross-section. Using data from the Periodic Labor Force Survey (PLFS), we show that removing couples in which spouses earn exactly the same amount almost entirely eliminates the discontinuity.[8] A wife who earns exactly as much as her husband neither outearns him nor earns less, so it is unclear whether equal earnings satisfy or violate the norm. Equal earnings could arise for reasons unrelated to the norm, including income misreporting or couples in the same industry or organization facing the same pay grades (Slotwinski and Roth, 2020; Zinovyeva and Tverdostup, 2021). Consistent with these explanations, earning exactly the same income is most common in households where both spouses work in casual labor markets or in the same industry and occupation. Our experimental results help to rule out breadwinning norms as the source of this bunching. More broadly, our results highlight the value of using experiments to isolate the relative importance of different mechanisms. Even in one of the most gender-conservative settings in the world, women's labor supply responds strongly to wages as opposed to norms around whether they outearn their husbands.

This paper contributes to the literature on how gender norms shape women's labor market outcomes. Previous studies suggest that norms depress female labor force participation (Bursztyn, Fujiwara and Pallais, 2017; Bursztyn, González and Yanagizawa-Drott, 2020; Folke and Rickne, 2020). However, evidence on how breadwinning norms affect labor supply is mixed.[9] Bertrand, Kamenica and Pan (2015) document that many married women in the US earn just below their husbands, which they attribute to social norms. Similar patterns emerge in many countries, including India (Gupta, 2022; Sharma, 2026), China (Zhao, Ye and Shi, 2022), and Germany (Sprengholz, Wieber and Holst, 2022). Others in-

[8]This has also been noted in the US (Kuehnle, Oberfichtner and Ostermann, 2021; Binder and Lam, 2022) and Sweden (Hederos and Stenberg, 2022).

[9]Some studies focus on other margins, including marriage formation (Dhar, 2023) and home production (Lippmann, Georgieff and Senik, 2020).

terpret these patterns differently. Slotwinski and Roth (2020) find similar patterns in Austria and Switzerland, but show that couples in which a woman outearns her husband misreport their incomes to satisfy a breadwinning norm; Binder and Lam (2022) argue that models of assortative matching without norms can explain the empirical evidence; and Zinovyeva and Tverdostup (2021) show that a similar discontinuity in Finland arises because wives' earnings rise toward their husband's when they work at the same firm. Hermle, Herold and Hildebrand (2024) find a kink, rather than a discontinuity, in German cross-sectional earnings distributions, and using a vignette experiment, attribute it to inequality aversion among women and breadwinning preferences among men. Ayan et al. (2026) use a carefully designed lab-in-the-field experiment in Bangladesh to test for breadwinning norms and two novel mechanisms, female homemaker norms and prestige norms, and find that the latter two are the more important constraints in their setting. We help to resolve the long-standing disagreement in this literature by conducting the first field experiment to test for breadwinning norms. We randomize wages over long-term jobs in a natural setting, allowing us to capture labor market decisions most likely to generalize to the broader economy. By tracing out women's full labor supply curve, we can test not only for a discontinuity, the prediction most discussed in the literature, but also for weaker forms of the norm, such as a change in elasticity or a kink at the husband's income.

We also contribute to the literature estimating labor supply elasticities. Women's responsiveness to wages has important implications for labor markets in developing countries. It determines how much female employment rises when labor demand expands, for example through export manufacturing (Heath and Mobarak, 2015); shapes employers' wage-setting power over women (Sharma, 2023); and underpins theories of structural transformation, which predict that higher-paying, non-stigmatized jobs draw women into the labor market as countries grow (Goldin, 1994). Our paper is the first to our knowledge to experimentally estimate labor supply elasticities for full-time, ongoing jobs in a low-income country. A small set of other studies in low-income countries estimate labor supply elasticities using

experimental variation for short-term or part-time jobs. Studies that randomize wages for short-term, part-time work find that labor supply is minimally responsive to wages (Goldberg, 2016; Jalota and Ho, 2024; Rajah, 2025), while a study in Ethiopia that randomizes wages for a full-time, three-month clerical position finds that doubling wages raises applications by 45 percent (Abebe, Caria and Ortiz-Ospina, 2021).[10] We estimate a larger elasticity of 1.7, for full-time, ongoing healthcare positions in India.[11] This pattern is consistent with labor supply responding more strongly to wages when jobs last longer, since fixed application costs are spread over a longer stream of earnings. Our results also complement evidence that expanding job opportunities, such as call-center jobs in rural India and garment manufacturing in Bangladesh, pull young, unmarried women into work (Jensen, 2012; Heath and Mobarak, 2015). In our setting, married women respond strongly to higher wages too.

Finally, this project contributes more broadly to the literature on female labor force participation in developing countries. Prior work over the last several years has documented the importance of a wide range of factors, including norms and social status (Field et al., 2021; Jayachandran, 2021; Agte and Bernhardt, 2023), marriage markets (Afridi et al., 2025), psychological barriers (McKelway, 2025), bargaining power (Sharma, 2023), working outside the home (Ho, Jalota and Karandikar, 2026), discrimination (Buchmann, Meyer and Sullivan, 2024), spousal jealousy (Rajah, 2025), and safety concerns (Siddique, 2022). Our results highlight the importance of identifying which specific norms bind in a given context. While breadwinning norms do not appear first-order in the Indian context, other norms, such as norms around women working at all (Hsu et al., 2026) or purity norms (Agte and Bernhardt, 2023; Garlick, Field and Vyborny, 2025), may be more important. And although much of the recent work on women's employment in developing countries has focused on social, psychological, and institutional barriers, our results emphasize that labor demand remains

[10]Evidence from middle-income countries, such as Mexico and China, also finds labor supply is responsive to wages for full-time jobs (Dal Bó, Finan and Rossi, 2013; He, Neumark and Weng, 2023), while Deserranno (2019) shows that higher expected earnings increase applications for a part-time, commission-based health-promoter position in Uganda.

[11]This elasticity estimate is in line with non-experimental estimates in other contexts (Sokolova and Sorensen, 2021).

an important driver of female labor force participation.

The remainder of this paper proceeds as follows: Section 2 describes our setting, Section 3 outlines our experimental design, Section 4 presents our empirical strategy, Section 5 reports the results, Section 6 uses nationally representative panel data to explore generalizability, Section 7 revisits the cross-sectional evidence, and Section 8 concludes.

2 Setting

2.1 Indian Context and Existing Evidence

Our study is set in India, a country with large gender gaps in the labor market (Klasen and Pieters, 2015; Fletcher, Pande and Moore, 2017; Agte et al., 2025). Only 34% of working-age women in India are in the labor force, compared to 77% of men, and women who do work earn roughly a third less than men (ILO, 2026). Conservative gender attitudes are also widespread. Most Indian adults agree that when jobs are scarce, men should have more right to a job than women, and 37% think a woman who works outside the home is likely to be criticized (Haerpfer et al., 2022). Previous work has argued that breadwinning norms bind more strongly in more conservative settings (Sprengholz, Wieber and Holst, 2022; Hermle, Herold and Hildebrand, 2024), suggesting that India may offer particularly favorable conditions for detecting the norm.

Observational data also support the idea that breadwinning norms could constrain women's employment in India. In the World Values Survey, 34% of Indian respondents agree that "If a woman earns more than her husband, it's almost certain to cause problems." This share is considerably higher than in many other countries, including the US, where only 12% agree with the same statement (Inglehart et al., 2014).[12] An existing literature, using cross-

[12]The share is 12% in Sweden, 19% in Germany, and 22% in China. We focus on Wave 6 of the WVS because, like our survey, it asks this question on a 3-point Likert scale. In Wave 7, the question was asked on a 5-point Likert scale, with 58% in India agreeing or strongly agreeing with the statement (Haerpfer et al., 2022).

sectional earnings distributions, has also argued that breadwinning norms are particularly restrictive to women's employment in India (Gupta, 2022; Sharma, 2026). These studies document a discontinuity in the distribution of the wife's share of household earnings as her income crosses her husband's that is much larger than in other studied contexts, with the density of couples falling by about 90% in India compared to 12% in the US (Gupta, 2022).

Figure 1 plots this distribution using data from the Periodic Labor Force Survey (PLFS). Consistent with prior work, there is a pronounced dip in the fraction of couples in which the wife earns slightly more than half of the couple's income.[13] While these patterns are particularly striking in India, it remains an open question whether they reflect breadwinning norms or other explanations, such as assortative matching in the marriage market, income misreporting, or couples in similar industries and occupations earning the same income. We return to these alternative explanations in Section 7.

2.2 Vocational Training Program

We implement the experiment in partnership with the Pratham Education Foundation, one of India's largest NGOs, which provides education and training services across the country. One of Pratham's major programs provides vocational training and placement services to young men and women aged 18–35, and has served over 300,000 young adults across India to date. The program offers two months of full-time training in a range of sectors, including healthcare, beauty, hospitality, electrical, automotive, and plumbing.

Placement services are a key part of the program. Pratham employs full-time placement officers, who build relationships with local employers and match graduates to jobs based on the graduates' preferences and current job opportunities. The placement process is particularly valuable to trainees because it gives them access to Pratham's relationships with employers. As a result, most graduates who complete the program find a job through the

[13] We use more recent data from the 2021-2024 PLFS relative to Gupta (2022). As such, the magnitude of the cross-sectional dip differs slightly, though we find the same overarching descriptive patterns. We describe the data in Appendix C.2.

placement process. In our study, we recontact graduates from the program and offer them additional placement services, which lets us embed our experiment in a natural setting that participants are already familiar with.

We identify women who graduated from Pratham's healthcare training at eight centers in North India, a region with particularly conservative gender attitudes and low female labor force participation. The centers were located in Lucknow, Prayagraj, Indore, Gorakhpur, Sehore, Ranchi, Vidisha, and Raipur (Appendix Figure A.1). Most jobs that Pratham's placement officers secure are in the same city as the training center.[14] Graduates are placed in hospitals or home care, depending on availability and their preferences. In hospitals, they typically work as nursing assistants; in home care, they work as caregivers, usually assisting the elderly. These jobs are middle-income by Indian standards. In our experiment, the median real job paid 10,000 rupees per month, which sits at the 64th percentile of the national income distribution for full-time working women.

Several features of these jobs make them particularly well suited to testing for breadwinning norms. First, the healthcare jobs are all long-term salaried positions, with no commission or bonus pay. These are exactly the kinds of jobs in which couples can compare incomes over a long period, both in our experiment and in the broader labor market. More than 80% of Pratham graduates remain in their job six months after being placed. Second, the jobs are all full-time, with shifts of 8, 10, 12, or 24 hours (for live-in roles). This makes it difficult, and in some cases impossible, for women to supplement their income with additional paid work. As a result, when we vary a job's wage in the experiment, we vary the total long-term income they expect to receive. Finally, after completing the training, many women are in a position to be earning above or below their husbands, depending on the job they apply for. In our experiment, 59% of participants' husbands earn more than the lowest-paying real job offered in the survey but less than the highest-paying one.

[14]The exception in our experiment was Vidisha, where we offered jobs in Indore, the state's largest city, because some graduates already lived there or were willing to relocate.

3 Research Design

We designed our experiment to test whether breadwinning norms (the idea that a married woman should earn less than her husband) constrain labor supply. To do so, we propose a test of tracing out married women's labor supply curve and observing whether or not there is a discontinuity or change in elasticity around the husband's income. Our approach benefits from eliminating demand-side factors that confound tests using cross-sectional data.

Our main pre-registered specification tests for a discontinuity in labor supply at the point where the wife's earnings exceed her husband's, the form of breadwinning norms most discussed in the literature. A discontinuity would arise if the household incurred a fixed cost from violating the norm (Figure 2a). Our approach also lets us test for weaker versions of the norm. For example, if the husband's income is uncertain or mismeasured, labor supply may instead flatten or slope downward around it (Figure 2b). Alternatively, if violating the norm becomes more costly the more the wife outearns her husband, labor supply may instead flatten or even slope downward above his income (Figure 2c). Standard models, by contrast, predict a smooth, upward-sloping labor supply curve with no change in elasticity or discontinuity around the husband's income (Figure 2d).

These underlying labor supply curves also make clear why a discontinuity in the cross-sectional earnings distribution is not a sharp test of the norm. If women have breadwinning preferences, it is possible that the distribution of the wife's share of household earnings shows a discontinuity if the underlying labor supply curve matches Figure 2a. However, if breadwinning preferences take the form shown in Figures 2b and 2c, the norm can bind without producing any discontinuity in the cross-sectional earnings distribution, which may instead appear smooth. On the other hand, if women have neoclassical preferences, as in Figure 2d, the earnings distribution can also show a discontinuity for reasons unrelated to labor supply. Couples in which the wife earns more may misreport their incomes in surveys, understating her earnings relative to his (Slotwinski and Roth, 2020). Couples who work at the same firm or in the same occupation may face common pay grades or wage

floors, which pull the wife's earnings up toward, but not beyond, her husband's (Zinovyeva and Tverdostup, 2021). Assortative matching combined with a small gender wage gap can also concentrate couples just below equal earnings, without any norm (Binder and Lam, 2022). Standard preferences could of course also produce a smooth earnings distribution. A discontinuity in the cross-section is therefore neither necessary nor sufficient evidence that the norm binds. Tracing out labor supply directly separates these cases, because each model predicts a distinct shape for the labor supply curve.

3.1 Study Details and Timeline

We collected data between October 2023 and March 2024. Female surveyors administered three separate surveys to participants over the phone in Hindi. In the first survey, we elicited the husband's income and women's application decisions over job opportunities with randomized wages. In the second survey, we re-elicited women's final job application decisions after giving them a few days to think about their choices and discuss them with their husbands. Finally, in the third survey, we measured gender attitudes and told participants their placement outcome.

3.1.1 Sample Recruitment

We recruited married female graduates of each training center by phone, using Pratham's database of past trainees. Surveyors attempted to call every woman who had graduated since 2017, including those who were single when they trained, since some may have married after graduating. Surveyors called each graduate, verified her identity, and introduced the study as a phone survey run by Pratham's head office, offering eligible participants the chance to learn about new Pratham placement opportunities. To avoid revealing that the study focused on married women, surveyors did not directly ask participants about their marital status during recruitment, but instead simply asked whether their husbands would be available to answer some questions later in the survey. Women who revealed that they

were unmarried, divorced, or separated were screened out. We continued the survey with married women either immediately or at a later time when the husband could join, in person or by conference call. When necessary, surveyors offered early-morning or evening calls to find a time when both spouses were free. We document selection into the study in Table A.1.

3.1.2 Survey 1: Demographics and Husband Wage Elicitation

After consent, we collected basic demographic information from the wife, including her age, religion, marital status, whether she lived with her husband, and how often she spoke with her husband if they lived apart. We again screened out participants who were unmarried, widowed, or separated.

Next, we elicited the husband's wage in front of the wife to create a common reference point that we could observe and use to randomize wage offers. This procedure ensures that we can measure and fix the wife's belief about her husband's income, the key conceptual object through which breadwinning norms should affect her labor supply preferences.[15] It also allows us to fix the husband's second-order beliefs: what he believes his wife believes to be his income. If he cares how his wife perceives him, this is also the reference point that should shape any breadwinning preferences he holds.[16]

To implement this, we asked the wife to put her husband on speakerphone if he was with her, or to add him to a conference call if he was not, creating a three-way call among the husband, the wife, and the surveyor. We collected similar demographic information from the husband to avoid making the income elicitation particularly salient. With his wife present on the call, the husband was asked to state his monthly wage. Workers in India commonly

[15] With observational or administrative data, even when researchers can accurately measure the husband's income, it may be difficult to observe the wife's beliefs about it.

[16] If the husband misreports his income, and breadwinning norms only operate through the husband's self-image (as opposed to his social image concerns or the wife's preferences), then we would expect a change in the elasticity of labor supply around his misreported income, rather than a discontinuity. As an additional robustness check, we also analyze the results restricting to the 93% of women who believe their husbands truthfully reported their salary (Appendix Table A.2).

describe their income as a monthly wage, particularly in middle-income salaried jobs such as the healthcare jobs offered to participants. If a husband gave an income range, surveyors asked for the average. We also asked husbands whether their wage was fixed (salaried) or varied month to month, because husbands with fixed salaries may be better able to compare incomes and enforce breadwinning preferences (something we can condition on later). We chose to elicit the husband's income before eliciting the wife's income to reduce the risk that the husband felt pressured to state a higher income than his wife's. Participants whose husbands refused to provide their salary were screened out.

We informed husbands that they could leave the call and then collected the wife's education, employment status, and, if she was working, her occupation and wage. We then asked the wife to remind us of her husband's wage. In 89% of cases, the wife's report exactly matched the husband's. If it differed, or if she was unsure, the surveyor asked her to check with her husband, and we used her reconciled answer. The resulting wage measure which was elicited from the husband, verified by the wife, and common knowledge to the couple, was the reference point around which wage offers were subsequently randomized. We then collected information on how many children they had before proceeding to the next section of the survey.

3.1.3 Survey 1: Wage Randomization and Initial Job Application Choices

Initial application choices: We then elicited the wife's labor supply choices over jobs with randomized wages. Surveyors asked participants whether they would be interested in applying for job opportunities found through Pratham's placement team and continued the survey with those who were interested. Because our experiment involves long-term jobs in an existing labor market, it was neither ethically nor logistically feasible to randomize the wages participants *received*. Instead, we mixed real and hypothetical jobs in the placement survey. Participants were truthfully told that the jobs were a mix of real jobs, secured by Pratham, and hypothetical jobs, similar to the jobs Pratham hoped to secure. Because

participants did not know which jobs were real, every choice was, in expectation, a high-stakes job application decision. The hypothetical jobs allowed us to randomize the wage offers as a function of the husband's income. Studying job application decisions also allows us to isolate labor supply preferences, because trainees are effectively guaranteed a job that is secured through the placement process.[17]

Surveyors read women 40 job postings, one by one, and women could choose whether or not to apply for each.[18] Women's initial application decisions were the key outcome measure in the first survey. Every job description contained the information typically available to trainees during the placement process: the position, location, monthly salary, hours, and any additional amenities.[19] Within each center, the hypothetical job ads were constructed to span the same attribute space as possible real jobs, but varied such that each position was unique.

Wage randomization: We randomized wages so that we would be well powered both to test our main specification, a discontinuity in labor supply, and to test for weaker forms of the norm, for example a change in elasticity for offers above the husband's income (Figure 2). To do so, we drew the wage offer for each hypothetical job from one of two distributions with equal probability: a triangular distribution between 0.9 and 1.1 times the husband's income, or a uniform distribution between 0.5 and 1.5 times the husband's income. The triangular distribution, over a narrow support, ensured we were well powered to test for a discontinuity. The uniform distribution, across a broad support, allowed us to trace out the shape of the labor supply curve and test for weaker versions of the norm. Appendix Figure A.2 shows the resulting density of wage offers for the hypothetical jobs. The wage offer was drawn independently for each individual-job choice. We also rounded wage offers to the

[17] This allows us to isolate trainees' preferences from demand-side factors, such as employers' preferences for specific workers.

[18] In most centers, the 40 jobs comprised 30 hypothetical and 10 real jobs; in Indore, Vidisha, and Gorakhpur, they comprised 35 hypothetical and 5 real jobs.

[19] At most centers, the real job opportunities advertised either a fixed salary, or a range of salaries depending on qualifications. At these centers, we would make clear to participants whether the salary was fixed and non-negotiable, or whether the employer paid a range of salaries (e.g. ₹4000-5000 per month). All hypothetical job ads contained a wage that was fixed and non-negotiable.

nearest 100 rupees. We discuss the econometric implications of this rounding in Section 4.1.

To ensure the wage offers for the hypothetical jobs were realistic, we pre-registered dropping participants whose husband's wage was more than double the highest real job wage, or less than a quarter of the lowest real job wage (at a given vocational training center).[20]

Incentive-compatible mechanism: We used an incentive-compatible mechanism to elicit participants' job application preferences. Surveyors informed participants that after the surveys, we would randomly select one of the real job offers and implement their application choice for that job. If a participant did not apply for the selected job, they were not placed. If they did, Pratham placed them into that position. If multiple individuals were matched and applied to the same job, then one of them was randomly selected to be placed.

In addition to placing participants into real jobs based on their responses, we charged a sizable placement fee to further ensure their choices were costly. Each woman received a 500-rupee voucher for participating in the study, from which 150 rupees was deducted if she was placed in a job.[21] Participants could choose whether to receive this as an online cash payment or as mobile phone credit. The fee was equivalent to a quarter of the median couple's total daily wages. Because the mechanism implements only one randomly selected choice and charges participants only for successful applications, it is optimal for them to consider each choice independently and to apply only for jobs they are willing to take. Because the number of jobs they apply to does not affect the probability of being selected for their preferred job, they should not, for example, only apply to those they find most attractive. We also explained this to participants in a straightforward manner, saying "The important thing to remember is that it is in your interest to simply consider each job opportunity on its own, and to honestly tell us whether you would be interested in applying for it."

Of participants who applied to the job they were matched with, 17% started the posi-

[20]For robustness, we also consider more stringent thresholds, for example participants whose husbands' wages are within the support of wage offers for the real jobs (Appendix Table A.3).

[21]In the first three centers surveyed (Lucknow, Prayagraj, and Ranchi), the participation voucher was 300 rupees, with the same 150-rupee fee.

tion (Table A.4).[22] This application-to-hire ratio is high in our setting because Pratham's relationship with employers effectively guarantees participants the position. By comparison, industry data from US hiring platforms show that only 0.3-0.6% of job applications typically result in a hire (CareerPlug, 2025; Ashby, 2026), suggesting the job application decisions in our setting are particularly consequential.

3.1.4 Survey 1: Spousal Communication and Revised Application Choices

Spousal communication treatment: Given the potential importance of spousal communication and intra-household information frictions in many low-income settings (Ashraf, 2009; Conlon et al., 2021; Lowe and McKelway, 2026), we also varied the information that was shared with husbands and the extent to which spousal communication was encouraged. We sent participants their job choices via WhatsApp or text message and randomized whether the choices were shared (1) only with the participant, or (2) with the participant *and* her husband, ensuring that the husband was fully informed of the wife's choices. We also encouraged participants in the latter group to discuss their choices with their family. If husbands have breadwinning preferences that women do not fully internalize, the communication treatment may strengthen the influence of the norm. Couples who shared a single phone number and couples where the husband declined to provide a phone number were excluded from this randomization, and details were sent to the one number they provided.

Revised application choices: Before we sent the choices, all participants were given an opportunity to withdraw any of the job applications they made. Participants randomized to share their choices with their husbands could therefore remove any choices before their husbands saw them, revealing whether the ability to hide their income shaped their choices. For example, a woman who applied for a job paying more than her husband, expecting to keep her salary from him, might withdraw that application once she learned he would see it.

[22] Our design does not seek to test for breadwinning norms after the application stage, given we only match participants to the real jobs in the survey for which wages are non-random; instead, we focus on women's job application choices for the hypothetical jobs in the placement survey for which wages are random.

3.1.5 Survey 2: Final Application Choices

The second phone survey was conducted several days later. We asked the wife whether she discussed the jobs with her family. Then, the surveyor went through each job she had expressed interest in, and the participant was asked for each job whether she was still interested in applying. This ensured that women had time to consider their decisions and discuss them with their family. We use the participants' final job application preferences as the primary outcome measure in our main specifications.

3.1.6 Survey 3: Gender Attitudes

After all participants had completed Survey 2, we ran the placement algorithm and administered the final phone survey. In Survey 3, we measured participants' gender attitudes and beliefs about peer attitudes. We then informed them of their placement outcome.

3.2 Sample Selection and Sample Size

Survey 1 was completed by 171 eligible women (N=5,345 *initial* job choices), Survey 2 by 155 eligible women (N=4,834 *final* job choices), and Survey 3 by 148 eligible women.

In our analysis, we restrict the sample to participants whose husbands are employed and provide their wage, so we can randomize wage offers around the husband's wage. As pre-registered, we also restrict our main analysis to participants whose husband's wage is neither much higher (2 times above the highest offer) nor much lower (4 times below the lowest offer) than the real job offers in their location, to ensure the job offers are realistic, and who applied for at least one hypothetical job. For our main analysis, we focus on participants' final choices, after they have had time to discuss the jobs with their husbands and family. Of the participants who started the survey, 18% dropped out during the demographics section (before any job choices were made), and 5% dropped out during the jobs section. We summarize sample selection and attrition in Table A.5.

4 Empirical Strategy

This section describes our formal econometric tests for breadwinning norms. The form of the norm most commonly studied in the literature implies a discontinuity in labor supply at the husband's income. Our main pre-registered specification tests for this directly. The norm could, however, impose costs in other ways. If couples cannot perfectly observe each other's income or control their incomes, the cost of violating the norm could flatten labor supply around the husband's income or make it slope downward. We test for this by estimating the slope of labor supply near the husband's income. If instead the cost grows the more the wife outearns her husband, labor supply could flatten above his income. We test for this by estimating the change in slope above the husband's income.

4.1 Main Specification: Discontinuity in Labor Supply

Our pre-registered main specification tests for a discontinuity at the husband's income. This may occur under a theory of breadwinning norms in which the couple incurs a fixed cost from violating the norm (as shown in Figure 2a). Under standard models, labor supply should be continuous around the husband's income. We estimate the following equation:

$$\text{Applied}_{ij} = \beta \mathbb{1}_{[\text{RelativeWageLevel}_{ij}>0]} + f(\text{RelativeWageLevel}_{ij}) + \gamma_i + \delta_j + g(d_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ij} \quad (1)$$

where i indexes participants and j indexes jobs. Applied_{ij} is a dummy variable equal to one if a participant applied to a given hypothetical job. We include participant and job fixed effects, and $g(d_{ij})$ controls for the log of the distance between the participant's residence and job j and its square. RelativeWageLevel is the wage of the job offer minus the husband's wage in rupees ($\text{RelativeWageLevel}_{ij} = \text{Wage offer}_{ij} - \text{Husband's income}_i$). The function $f(\text{RelativeWageLevel}_{ij})$ denotes a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights. In our main pre-registered specification, we use a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees on

either side of the husband's income, but also consider bandwidths of 1,000 and 3,000 rupees for robustness. As pre-registered, we drop participants whose randomized wage offers do not span the full support of the bandwidth. Since wage offers range from 0.5 to 1.5 times the husband's income, we drop households where the husband earns less than 2,000, 4,000, and 6,000 rupees for the 1,000-, 2,000-, and 3,000-rupee bandwidths, respectively. We use robust standard errors because wages are randomized at the individual-job level.[23]

To make the offers appear realistic, we round randomized job offers to the nearest 100 rupees. Because the husband's wage is also likely to be a multiple of 100 rupees, this rounding makes it more likely that women with low-earning husbands receive a wage offer exactly equal to their husband's.[24] Since the rounding procedure increases the probability of being at the cutoff for participants with low-earning husbands, we pre-registered using inverse probability weights to recover an unbiased estimate of our coefficient of interest, β. We also report estimates without them for completeness and find similar results (Appendix Table A.7).

Since it is not obvious whether the wife earning the same amount as the husband violates or adheres to the norm, we also present results under alternative definitions of the cutoff. If the norm only requires that the wife not outearn her husband, equal offers satisfy it and belong below the cutoff, as in our main specification. If it requires that she earn strictly less, equal offers violate it and belong above the cutoff. We report both these specifications, as well as the results when we exclude offers equal to the husband's income.

[23]Because wages are randomized at the individual-job level, clustering at the individual level does not meaningfully affect precision (see Table A.6).

[24]For example, a woman whose husband earns 2,000 rupees per month will receive wage offers randomized between 1,000 and 3,000 rupees per month. Given the narrow support, more of these offers will be exactly at 2,000 rupees. A woman whose husband earns 10,000 rupees per month will receive wage offers randomized between 5,000 and 15,000 rupees per month, and will therefore see relatively fewer offers exactly at 10,000 rupees.

4.2 Slope of the Labor Supply Curve

Next, we estimate the slope of women's labor supply near their husbands' income. Breadwinning norms will produce a negative slope in labor supply, as opposed to a discontinuity, if the couple cannot perfectly control their current or future incomes, or if incomes are mismeasured (Figure 2b). Standard models predict a positive slope. We estimate the following equation:

$$\text{Applied}_{ij} = \alpha + \beta \text{RelativeWage}_{ij} + \gamma_i + \delta_j + g(d_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ij} \tag{2}$$

where we restrict the sample to offers in a narrow band around the husband's income. RelativeWage_{ij} is the ratio of the unrounded wage offer to the husband's income ($\text{RelativeWage}_{ij} = \frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}_{ij}}{\text{Husband's income}_i}$). We pre-registered using the unrounded wage offers in this specification to avoid the econometric issues created by rounding wage offers to the nearest 100 rupees (see Section 4.1). We estimate this equation for $\text{RelativeWage}_{ij} \in [0.8, 1.2]$, $[0.9, 1.1]$, and $[0.95, 1.05]$ using robust standard errors.

4.3 Difference in Means

We then estimate the simplest test of the norm, a difference in average labor supply near the husband's income, which could detect breadwinning norms of the forms described in Figures 2a or 2b. In this specification, breadwinning norms and neoclassical models again make opposite predictions. Breadwinning norms predict that labor supply should be *lower* for wages slightly above the husband's income than for wages slightly below, while neoclassical models predict labor supply should be *higher*. We estimate the following equation:

$$\text{Applied}_{ij} = \alpha + \beta \text{WageAboveHusband}_{ij} + \gamma_i + \delta_j + g(d_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ij} \tag{3}$$

where $\text{WageAboveHusband}_{ij} = 1$ when the offered (rounded) wage exceeds the husband's wage. We estimate Equation 3 for bandwidths of $[-500, 500]$, $[-1000, 1000]$, $[-2000, 2000]$,

and $[-3000, 3000]$ around the husband's income. In this case, rounding to the nearest 100 rupees does not bias our estimates, because the treatment variable is binary and we include individual fixed effects. We use robust standard errors in all specifications.

4.4 Change in Slope of the Labor Supply Curve

Finally, we test for a change in the slope of the labor supply curve on either side of the husband's income. If the cost of violating the norm rises with the amount by which the wife outearns her husband, then her labor supply may flatten for wage offers above the husband's income (Figure 2c). We estimate a continuous linear spline with a kink at the husband's income:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Applied}_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 \left(\text{RelativeWage}_{ij} - 1\right) + \beta_2 \max\left(\text{RelativeWage}_{ij} - 1, 0\right) \\ + \gamma_i + \delta_j + g(d_{ij}) + \varepsilon_{ij} \end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

where RelativeWage_{ij} is the ratio of the unrounded wage offer to the husband's income ($\text{RelativeWage}_{ij} = \frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}_{ij}}{\text{Husband's income}_i}$). β_2 tests for a change in the slope. We estimate this equation for $\text{RelativeWage}_{ij} \in [0.8, 1.2]$, $[0.9, 1.1]$, and $[0.95, 1.05]$ and use robust standard errors.

4.5 Spousal Communication Treatment

We also test how the husband's involvement in decision making affects the influence of breadwinning norms. We estimate our main specification separately on participants' initial and final choices, and compare estimates between the subsample randomly assigned to have the husband receive the list of job choices and the control subsample. Women who share a phone number with their husband or whose husbands decline to provide their number are not included in this exercise.

5 Results

We begin by describing sample characteristics and highlighting several features of our sample that suggest it would be well suited for testing the norm. We then turn to our experimental results, which compare predictions of a neoclassical model to predictions of breadwinning norms across the different forms they may take. Within the experimental results, we first plot our data across the full support of (randomized) wage offers to visually assess the shape of women's labor supply curve. We then run our pre-registered specifications, which test for the specific variants of the norm.

5.1 Sample Characteristics

Table 1 describes our sample demographics. The average age of women in our sample was 27, 90% were Hindu, and about half had finished college. By construction, all of the women in our sample had completed Pratham's vocational training program for healthcare work, were interested in new job opportunities, and had husbands who were working. Seventy-nine percent had worked before, and 19% were currently working. This pattern likely arises because completing the training program would not have made sense for women who were never interested in working, while placement opportunities may be of less interest to women who are currently working.

Our sample exhibits conservative gender attitudes and behaviors. Seventy-two percent say their husband or in-laws have more say than they do about their career decision. And 30% agree with the statement that it would cause problems in a marriage if a wife earned more than her husband, raising the possibility that these norms affect their labor supply. This figure is similar to the national average of 34% and considerably higher than in the US (Inglehart et al., 2014). In Table A.8, we compare our experimental sample's demographics and gender attitudes to married women in North India aged 18 to 32 who have finished 12th grade. The two samples are similar over a broad range of characteristics, including

the proportion with children, the proportion who have finished college, and the wife's share of household earnings. The women in our sample are more likely to be employed and, conditional on working, have lower average incomes but a slightly higher median income. Among women who were already working, the median participant in our sample sits at about the 65th percentile of the North Indian comparison sample's income distribution.

We also confirm that our setting is conducive to detecting the norm. First, we find that all working women report that their husband knows exactly how much they earn, minimizing any risk that participants can hide their income from their husbands.[25] Second, 97% of women say that they discussed the job opportunities with their family before making their final choices in the second survey. Finally, 93% of women say in the final survey that they thought their husband's stated income in the initial survey was accurate.[26]

5.2 Relative Earnings in Experimental Sample

Figure 3a plots the wife's share of earnings for couples in our sample where the wife was already working. Our experimental sample produces similar patterns to observational results from India, the US, and other countries, where many more women earn weakly less than their husbands than earn more. We also document this pattern using representative data from the PLFS on a larger sample of similar households: married women in North India aged 18 to 32 who have finished 12th grade (Figure 3b).

5.3 Experimental Results

5.3.1 Binned Scatter Plots

We begin by simply plotting the binned means of job application rates on wage offers relative to the husband's income ($\frac{\text{Wage of job offered}}{\text{Wage of husband}}$) in Figure 4. The top panels fit the data with

[25] In the spousal communication treatment, we also share the wife's job application choices with the husband to rule out the possibility of income hiding.

[26] Of the 7% of women who thought their husband's reported income was not accurate, about half stated this was due to having an income that fluctuates over time.

a local polynomial regression at different stages in the decision-making process: women's *initial* labor supply choices, their *revised* choices after some learned that their choices would be sent to their husbands, and their *final* choices after having several days to speak with their family. At all decision stages, we see no visual evidence of a flattening or decreasing labor supply around the husband's income. These results suggest that proximity of the wage to the husband's income has no effect on whether a woman applies for the job. Instead, labor supply is monotonically increasing in the wage, consistent with neoclassical models. While overall labor supply falls between women's *initial* and *final* choices, there appears to be no differential decline for jobs with wage offers above or below the husband's.[27] We also find that almost no applications are rescinded at the *revised* stage. This is consistent with women's decisions not being driven by a belief that they would be able to hide the salary from their husband.

In the bottom panels, we fit the data with a piecewise linear regression and find remarkably similar slopes in labor supply for wage offers above and below the husband's income. There also appears to be no evidence of a discontinuity when we fit a linear model to data over the full support of wage offers. These graphs suggest not only that there is no discontinuity, but also that there is no flattening, downward slope, or any other change in the behavior of labor supply around the husband's income. In the following sections, we conduct our formal pre-registered statistical tests, which focus on labor supply choices with wage offers close to the husband's income.

5.3.2 Main Specification: Discontinuity in Labor Supply

In our main specification, we find no evidence of a discontinuity in labor supply around the husband's income. In Table 2 Panel A, we formally test for a discontinuity around the husband's income by estimating Equation 1. Across specifications, we find precisely estimated nulls and can reject negative discontinuities as small as 3.3 percentage points in

[27]The reduction in labor supply across the stages is partly mechanical, given women can only rescind their application to a given job in the *revised* and *final* stages.

our main pre-registered test (Figure 5).

These results are robust across a broad set of alternative specifications. This includes using different statistical models, such as varying the bandwidth used to estimate the discontinuity (Figure A.3 and Table 2), removing control variables (Table 3), and removing the inverse probability weights that correct for wages being rounded to the nearest 100 rupees (Table A.7). We also allow for different possible definitions of the norm. To account for the possibility that the norm binds as soon as the wife's income equals the husband's, we also include wage offers equal to the husband's income above the cutoff and can reject negative discontinuities as small as 1.5 percentage points (Table 3, column 8). We can also treat equal wage offers as ambiguous and drop these observations, in which case we reject discontinuities as small as 2.5 percentage points (Table 3, column 5). We also find similar patterns for choices made in the initial survey and for final choices made after women had additional time to speak with their husbands, suggesting that the null cannot be explained by a lack of spousal communication or time to consider spousal preferences (Figure A.4 and Table A.9).

5.3.3 Heterogeneity

In Table 4, we explore whether breadwinning preferences emerge in pre-registered subsamples where one might expect these norms to bind most strongly. We estimate Equation 1 among participants who were above median in terms of: (a) agreeing with the World Values Survey statement that a woman outearning her husband would cause problems; (b) the proportion of their peers who would agree with the same statement; (c) believing that outearning their husband would cause problems in their own marriage; (d) whether they practiced purdah (veiling); (e) an index of measures (a)–(d); and (f) whether their husband had a salaried income, which makes it easier to compare incomes.

Across all these subgroups, we do not find evidence consistent with breadwinning norms constraining labor supply. In most specifications, we find discontinuity estimates close to

zero, consistent with neoclassical models, and can rule out relatively small negative discontinuities. We find a marginally significant negative discontinuity in households where women think outearning their husbands would cause problems in their own marriage ($p = 0.08$, without multiple hypothesis corrections), but this effect disappears entirely once we include wage offers equal to the husband's income to the right of the cutoff. We present these results in Figure 6.

Finally, in Table A.10, we test the influence of the husband's presence during the first survey, since his physical presence may allow him to influence his wife's choices more directly. Even if the husband is present with the wife during the first survey (rather than joining the survey via a conference call), we do not find evidence of a negative discontinuity in labor supply.

5.3.4 Slope of the Labor Supply Curve

In Table 2 Panel B, we test for a negative slope in labor supply near the husband's income, which may occur if couples cannot perfectly control their income or if income is mismeasured. Again, we find evidence strongly consistent with neoclassical models: a one percent increase in wages raises job application rates by between 0.24 and 0.63 percentage points. The patterns are consistent across bandwidths, choices made in the initial and final surveys (Table A.11), and with and without controls (Table A.12).

5.3.5 Difference in Means

In Table 2 Panel C, we present results for an alternative test of breadwinning norms: a simple difference in means. While the theory of breadwinning norms predicts a *decrease* in labor supply for wage offers slightly above the husband's income (as compared to those slightly below), neoclassical models predict an *increase* in labor supply.

Labor supply increases significantly for wage offers above the husband's income, consistent with neoclassical models. This is true across the bandwidths we pre-registered, where

we estimate labor supply to be between 3 and 7 percentage points higher for wage offers above the husband's income compared to those below. As expected, the estimate increases with the bandwidth given labor supply is monotonically increasing. The patterns are similar in participants' initial and final job application choices (Table A.13) and in specifications with and without controls (Table A.14).

5.3.6 Change in Slope of the Labor Supply Curve

We then test whether there is a change in the slope of labor supply at the husband's income, which could occur if the cost of violating the norm increases by the extent to which the wife outearns the husband. To do so, we estimate a piecewise linear regression for wage offers close to the husband's income (Equation 4). Across specifications, we do not find evidence of a reduction in the slope of labor supply above the husband's income (Table A.15 and Table A.16). This is consistent with the patterns we observe across the full support of wage offers in Figure 4, where fitting a piecewise linear function on either side of the husband's income appears approximately continuous with no slope change.

5.3.7 Elasticity Estimates

In Table 5, we estimate women's labor supply elasticity. To do so, we regress their job applications on log wages and divide the coefficient we obtain by the average job application rate. We again restrict the analysis to the hypothetical jobs, which have random variation in wages. Applications increase significantly with wages, and we calculate an elasticity of approximately 1.7. Our study is the first to our knowledge to experimentally estimate labor supply elasticities over ongoing, full-time jobs in a low-income context. The elasticity we estimate is higher than experimental studies in developing countries involving short-term, part-time contracts (Goldberg, 2016; Jalota and Ho, 2024; Rajah, 2025), where women are minimally responsive to higher wages, as well as studies involving short-term, full-time contracts (Abebe, Caria and Ortiz-Ospina, 2021). This pattern is consistent with labor

supply responding more strongly to wages when jobs last longer, since fixed costs of starting a job are spread over a longer stream of earnings. There are many more studies that have estimated labor supply elasticities using non-experimental approaches, and our elasticity estimate is broadly in line with these estimates (Sokolova and Sorensen, 2021). We also calculate elasticities at the individual level and find that women who are currently in the labor market have higher labor supply elasticities (Table A.17). The high elasticities we document also help to demonstrate that the women in our sample were paying close attention to the features of the job, and in particular, the wage offers.

5.3.8 Spousal Communication Treatment

We test whether spousal involvement affects women's labor supply choices by randomizing whether we (i) sent their job application choices to the trainees and their husbands and encouraged women to discuss them; or (ii) sent them only to the trainees. A breadwinning norm may only appear in the decisions of the treated group if husbands value earning more than their wives, but wives do not internalize these preferences in their initial decisions, or if wives believe they can hide their salary from their husbands. Table A.18 tests for balance across the two treatment arms. Though the baseline covariates do not jointly predict treatment, there is some imbalance in the proportion of jobs women initially apply to before being treated ($p = 0.037$).

The spousal communication treatment has no overall impact on either the proportion of women who discuss the jobs with their family (Table A.19, column 1) or their final labor supply choices once we control for baseline covariates (Table A.19, column 6). This is perhaps unsurprising given 97% of women in the control group discuss their job application choices with their family. We also do not find any evidence of a negative discontinuity in labor supply for participants who were randomized to the spousal communication treatment, whose husbands were perfectly informed of their choices (Table A.20, column 4). These results help to rule out the possibility that our findings are driven by a lack of spousal involvement.

5.3.9 Summary of Results

Across all our tests, which account for the different potential forms of breadwinning norms and consider different bandwidths, stages of decision making, and regression controls, we find no evidence of breadwinning norms limiting women's labor supply. These patterns hold even among subsamples where we ex ante hypothesized breadwinning norms may be strongest. Instead, we find that women's job applications respond strongly to wages (even around their husbands' income), with a 1% increase in wages producing a 1.7% increase in labor supply. In the following section, we consider potential confounds and alternative explanations for our results.

5.4 Alternative Channels and Confounds

5.4.1 Selection into the Experiment

In designing the experiment, we specifically chose a setting in which women were interested in working and could plausibly earn more than their husbands, both necessary conditions for detecting the norm. One concern with selecting such a sample is that it may be unusually gender-progressive or unrepresentative of the broader population. We address this concern by working in some of the most gender-conservative states in India. All of these states are in North India, where previous work finds the largest discontinuities in the cross-section (Gupta, 2022). Our participants hold conservative views, with 30% agreeing that a wife outearning her husband would cause problems, close to the national average of 34% and far above the 12% in the US (see Section 5.1). They are also similar to a representative sample of comparable women in North India on a broad range of characteristics (Table A.8).

Our sample's incomes also make it well suited to testing the norm. The couples in the experiment are middle-income. At baseline, the quartiles of couple income sit at the 36th, 58th, and 75th percentiles of the national income distribution. In addition, 59% of husbands earn more than the lowest-paying real job in our experiment and less than the highest-

paying one (at a given training center), so many women could earn either more or less than their husbands depending on the job they choose. Finally, the cross-sectional pattern that motivated this literature also appears in our setting. Among couples in which both spouses work, few wives earn just more than their husbands, both in our experimental sample and in a larger comparison sample of married women in North India aged 18 to 32 who have finished 12th grade (Figure 3).

5.4.2 Income Mismeasurement

Another concern is that we mismeasure the wife's or husband's income. For wives, the risk is that she could supplement the jobs we offered her with additional work, leading us to understate her total income. We limit this concern in our design by specifically selecting a vocational training program that only offered full-time jobs, which leave little time for additional work. Table A.21 tests this directly by splitting job offers by their work hours. Even for jobs that advertised 12-hour shifts or 24-hour shifts (live-in jobs), where holding a second job would be difficult or impossible, we find no evidence of a discontinuity in labor supply.

For husbands, the risk is that some misstated their income in the initial survey, to hide their income from their wives, to conform to breadwinning norms, or because their income varies month to month. Women in these households may not have believed their husband's stated wage and may therefore have been making choices relative to a reference point we do not observe. To test this, we asked women in the final survey whether their husband truthfully stated his income in the initial survey. Ninety-three percent said they thought that he had, suggesting that misreporting was rare.[28] In addition to this, in Table A.2, we run our main specification on women who said their husband accurately reported his income, women whose husbands had a salaried income, and women whose husbands quoted a single

[28]Of the 7% of women who thought their husband's reported income was inaccurate, about half said this was because his income fluctuates over time, while the remainder stated other reasons, including intentional misreporting, though not out of a desire to conform to breadwinning norms.

number (as opposed to a salary range) when initially asked about his wage. We find no evidence of breadwinning norms in any of these subsamples.[29]

5.4.3 Realistic Offers and Demand Effects

We piloted the instrument extensively to confirm that participants could not distinguish between the real and hypothetical offers. Still, some participants may have found the wages in the hypothetical jobs to be unrealistically high or low. If so, they may not have engaged seriously with the job application exercise, making breadwinning norms harder to detect. To minimize this risk, we pre-registered including only participants whose husbands earned more than a quarter of the lowest real wage and less than double the highest real wage at a given center. Table A.3 applies a more stringent restriction, keeping only the 59% of participants whose husbands earned more than the lowest real wage offer and less than the highest real wage offer. We again find no evidence of a negative discontinuity.

Several features of our design limit the risk of experimenter demand effects. We ensured choices were costly by charging participants a fee to apply for jobs and matching them into real jobs based on their application decisions. We also concealed the purpose of the study by eliciting the husband's income alongside other demographic information and by asking attitudinal questions, including those about breadwinning norms, after participants had finalized their application decisions. To check whether participants guessed the purpose of the study, we asked them at the end of the final survey what they thought the survey was about. Ninety-three percent mentioned employment and placement, and none mentioned breadwinning norms or concerns about outearning their husbands (Figure A.5).

[29] We are less concerned about wives misreporting incomes to their husbands because women in the spousal communication treatment arm could not hide their wages as their husbands were also sent the details of each offer. In addition, all working women in our experiment stated that their husbands knew exactly how much they earned.

5.4.4 Participant Engagement and Effort

Another possible concern is that participants did not engage seriously with the job application process. If they were not paying attention or not carefully considering the offers, our elicitation would not accurately capture their preferences. Our design makes this unlikely. Applying through Pratham was high stakes, because it gave participants access to job openings through Pratham's existing relationships with local employers. We also included only participants who said in the first survey that they were interested in new placement opportunities, and we made applying costly by deducting a placement fee from those placed in a job.

The data confirm participants engaged carefully with the job opportunities presented in the survey. They responded to job attributes as one would expect, responding positively to wages, negatively to distance, and negatively to longer hours (Table A.22, column 1). At the end of the final survey, we also asked participants what their main considerations were when deciding which jobs to apply for.[30] Strikingly, participants who named an attribute as important to them were significantly more responsive to that attribute in their application decisions (Table A.22, column 2). Taken together, the evidence suggests that participants were attentive and engaged throughout the job application process.

5.4.5 Norms Binding After Applications

Finally, one might be concerned that our experiment only captures the application stage of labor supply, and that perhaps breadwinning norms only affect women's choices when they decide whether to start a job or whether to stay in it. Because participants made their application choices carefully (as described above), this explanation would require that norms matter a great deal at later stages but that women do not anticipate them when applying. This seems unlikely in our setting: 79% of the women in our sample had worked before,

[30]Consistent with our quantitative results, no participant mentioned concerns about outearning her husband or about relative earnings. The most common responses were location, hours of work, and wages (Figure A.6).

likely in similar jobs, and so had the opportunity to learn husbands' preferences directly or through peers. If norms bind later, we should at least see them at the application stage among women with the most work experience, who are best informed about their husbands' preferences. We find no such evidence. Even among women who have worked since marriage or who are currently working, there is no negative discontinuity in labor supply (Table A.23). Women who are currently working in fact respond most strongly to wage offers around their husband's income relative to other participants (Table A.17). In the next section, we also test directly whether norms bind after women start working, using India's largest household panel dataset.

6 Nationally Representative Panel Data

We complement our experimental analysis with nationally representative panel data from the Consumer Pyramids Household Survey (CPHS) from 2015 to 2025. The CPHS is India's largest household panel dataset and records each household member's monthly income and employment status. We use these data to test whether a woman outearning her husband predicts her subsequently exiting the labor market. Specifically, we run the following specification:

$$\begin{aligned}\text{Employed}_{i,t+13} = \beta_1 \,\text{WifeEarnsMore}_{it} + \beta_2 \,\text{WifeShare}_{it} \\ + \beta_3 \,\text{WifeEarnsMore}_{it} \times \text{WifeShare}_{it} + \gamma X_{it} + \mu_i + \tau_t + \varepsilon_{it}\end{aligned} \tag{5}$$

where $\text{Employed}_{i,t+13}$ is an indicator for the wife being employed at the household visit 13 months after month t,[31] $\text{WifeEarnsMore}_{it}$ is an indicator for the wife earning strictly more than her husband, and WifeShare_{it} is her share of the couple's wage income.[32] X_{it} contains

[31] CPHS visits each household every four months, recording each member's income for each of the preceding four months and their employment status on the day of the visit. We measure income in the month before a visit, which households are likely to recall most accurately, and employment at the visit one year later, 13 months after the income month.

[32] We center WifeShare_{it} at one half, subtracting 0.5 from the wife's share of the couple's income.

indicators for only the wife earning, only the husband earning, and neither spouse earning, and μ_i and τ_t are couple and month fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the couple level.

Variation in the wife's and husband's incomes is not random and may be correlated with many omitted factors. However, as long as these factors do not change discontinuously when the wife's income crosses her husband's, if breadwinning norms bind after a woman takes a job, then the norm makes a clear prediction: earning slightly more than her husband, as opposed to slightly less, should depress her future labor supply.

Table 6 presents the results. Column 1 shows the baseline specification (Equation 5). Columns 2–4 progressively add controls. Column 2 adds log couple income; column 3 interacts the couple and month fixed effects with the indicators for only the wife earning, only the husband earning, and neither spouse earning; and column 4 adds controls for the spouses' ages squared and whether they have children. Across all specifications, we find no evidence consistent with breadwinning norms. A woman outearning her husband does not predict her subsequently leaving the labor market, and we can rule out reductions in labor supply as small as 2.3 percentage points (relative to a mean employment rate of 56 percent 13 months later).

The panel data and the experiment are complementary. On its own, the panel analysis could produce a null even if breadwinning norms bind, provided they operate when women choose which jobs to take. In that case, women for whom the norm binds would avoid jobs that pay more than their husbands earn, and so would never be observed outearning them. Our experiment helps rule out this possibility by showing that the norm does not affect women's job application decisions. In turn, the panel data extend our results beyond the experimental sample and help rule out the possibility that breadwinning norms bind only after women have taken up a job. Taken together, the two sources of evidence suggest that breadwinning norms do not constrain married women's labor supply in India, both when women select jobs and after they start working.

7 Revisiting the Cross-Sectional Evidence

The goal of this paper is not to explain the discontinuity in the cross-sectional distribution of the wife's share of spousal earnings, but rather to test whether breadwinning norms affect married women's labor supply decisions. In this section, however, we attempt to reconcile the prior literature with our experimental findings and to assess whether factors unrelated to breadwinning norms could *plausibly* explain the cross-sectional patterns in India.

Other mechanisms could also generate the cross-sectional patterns. Reporting behavior, either rounding wages or misreporting to comply with a breadwinning norm, can generate a discontinuity (Slotwinski and Roth, 2020). Couples working in the same industry or occupation may be subject to the same wage floors or minimum wages, and couples working at the same firm may share pay grades or use information about each other's wages when negotiating (Zinovyeva and Tverdostup, 2021; Hederos and Stenberg, 2022). These mechanisms could produce a high fraction of women earning exactly the same amount as their husbands.

To explore these possibilities, we examine whether a high prevalence of equal earners can explain the discontinuity in India. Using data from the Periodic Labor Force Survey from July 2021 to June 2024, we again plot the wife's share of household earnings, this time using smaller bins that allow us to see more clearly how removing equal earners affects the distribution (Figure 7a). As before, the full distribution shows a sharp drop in the share of couples in which the wife earns just more than her husband. In Figure 7b, we simply remove equal-earning couples and find that doing so eliminates any appearance of a discontinuity at the husband's income. The pattern is even more striking in narrower bins. Figures 7c and 7d clearly display a large point mass at exactly 0.5 and no bunching below the husband's income.

We then investigate what might explain the mass of equal earners. Casual labor appears to account for a substantial part of the mass. In 54% of couples earning the same amount, both spouses report working in casual labor. Equal earnings in these couples could reflect institutional features such as the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee

Scheme (MGNREGS), India's national rural workfare program, which pays men and women the same daily wage. In our data, two-thirds of couples in which both spouses report participating in MGNREGS have identical earnings. Equal earnings in casual labor could also arise when couples receive joint offers and report splitting the wage. Another 31% of equal earners have both spouses in regular salaried work, and 69% of these share an industry or occupation, consistent with common pay grades, rounding of similar salaries, or information sharing when bargaining (Zinovyeva and Tverdostup, 2021). It is also possible that assortative matching in the marriage market leads to couples earning similar incomes (Binder and Lam, 2022), which rounding in reported earnings could then make exactly equal (as discussed in more detail below).

The mass of equal earners is unlikely to be driven by breadwinning norms. A theory of breadwinning norms does not say whether a wife who earns exactly as much as her husband satisfies or violates the norm. Placing this large mass of equal earners just below the cutoff produces the familiar drop in the distribution just above one half. But if equal earnings are instead treated as violating the norm, and these couples are placed just above the cutoff, the discontinuity becomes *positive*, as if the norm required women to earn *more* than their husbands. Even if equal earnings do not violate the norm, our experiment rules out the possibility that the mass of equal earners is driven by breadwinning norms because our main specification assigns wage offers equal to the husband's income to the left of the cutoff, and we still find no discontinuity in labor supply.[33] Finally, mass points are also common at other simple divisions of household income. Appendix Table A.24 lists the largest mass points in the wife's share of couple earnings in order of frequency: after one-half (4.3% of couples), the most common are one-third (3.0%), two-fifths (2.1%), and one-quarter (1.7%). Breadwinning norms cannot explain these other common splits, which suggests that at least some of the point mass at one-half comes from couples reporting rounded incomes.

Though the mass of equal earners appears to explain the cross-sectional discontinuity,

[33]For robustness, we also estimate specifications that drop wage offers equal to the husband's income or assign them to the right of the cutoff, and find similar results (Table 3).

the absence of a discontinuity once equal earners are removed does not on its own rule out breadwinning norms (as outlined in Section 3). A discontinuity in the earnings distribution is a demanding test of the norm. It requires both that violating the norm imposes a fixed cost, so that labor supply drops sharply at the husband's income (Figure 2a), and that couples can precisely control their incomes. If the norm binds but couples cannot precisely control their incomes, labor supply may instead slope downward around the husband's income (Figure 2b), producing a smooth earnings distribution. Similarly, if violating the norm becomes more costly the more the wife outearns her husband, labor supply may flatten above his income (Figure 2c), again without a discontinuity in the cross-section. These distinct possibilities highlight the importance of experimentally testing for breadwinning norms by isolating married women's labor supply.

8 Conclusion

In this paper, we conduct what is, to our knowledge, the first field experiment testing whether breadwinning norms affect women's labor supply, leveraging experimental variation in wage offers made to married women in India. While observational studies find that few wives earn just more than their husbands, we find no drop in women's labor supply when wage offers exceed their husbands' income. Instead, labor supply increases monotonically with wages, consistent with standard economic models. The results hold across specifications and in subsamples where the norm might be expected to bind most strongly, such as households with conservative gender attitudes and those in which the husband earns a fixed salary, which provides a clear benchmark for comparison. Our findings suggest that breadwinning norms do not constrain married women's labor supply. We focus on women's employment, a particularly important margin and the focus of much of the literature, and our study does not speak directly to other margins, such as marriage formation, marital conflict, or subjective well-being.

Our findings show that, even among women living in highly conservative settings, neoclassical forces remain an important determinant of labor supply. In our setting, a 1% increase in the wage offer raises women's labor supply by about 1.7%. These results help explain why structural changes that create higher-paying work opportunities have increased women's employment (Jensen, 2012; Heath and Mobarak, 2015). While previous studies largely document these effects among young, unmarried women, we find that married women in India also respond strongly to wages. The results also imply that policies that expand employment opportunities for women, such as industrial policies and workfare programs, are unlikely to be undermined by breadwinning norms. For example, MGNREGS pays men and women the same wage. If breadwinning norms were first-order, one might worry that the prospect of earning as much as their husbands would deter some women from taking up the scheme. Our results suggest that such concerns are unfounded. Instead, the relatively high pay may be particularly attractive to women accustomed to large gender wage gaps, helping explain why take-up is especially high among women (Fletcher, Pande and Moore, 2017).

More broadly, our results highlight the importance of identifying which specific norms bind in a given social context. Social norms undoubtedly influence women's employment decisions in India, but which norms bind matters greatly for policy. Stated gender attitudes alone are unlikely to answer this question. In our sample, 30% of married women agree that it would cause problems if a woman earned more than her husband, yet we find no evidence that these attitudes constrain behavior. In other contexts, norms may strongly restrict behavior even when people's private attitudes do not support them (Bursztyn, González and Yanagizawa-Drott, 2020). Such gaps between stated attitudes and behavior may be especially important when studying consequential decisions, such as whether women work. Our study demonstrates the value of using experimental approaches to isolate the specific social barriers that shape women's employment behavior. Future work should apply these approaches to other norms, such as those around women's purity, domestic work, or occupational choice, and to policies that seek to raise women's wages.

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Figures

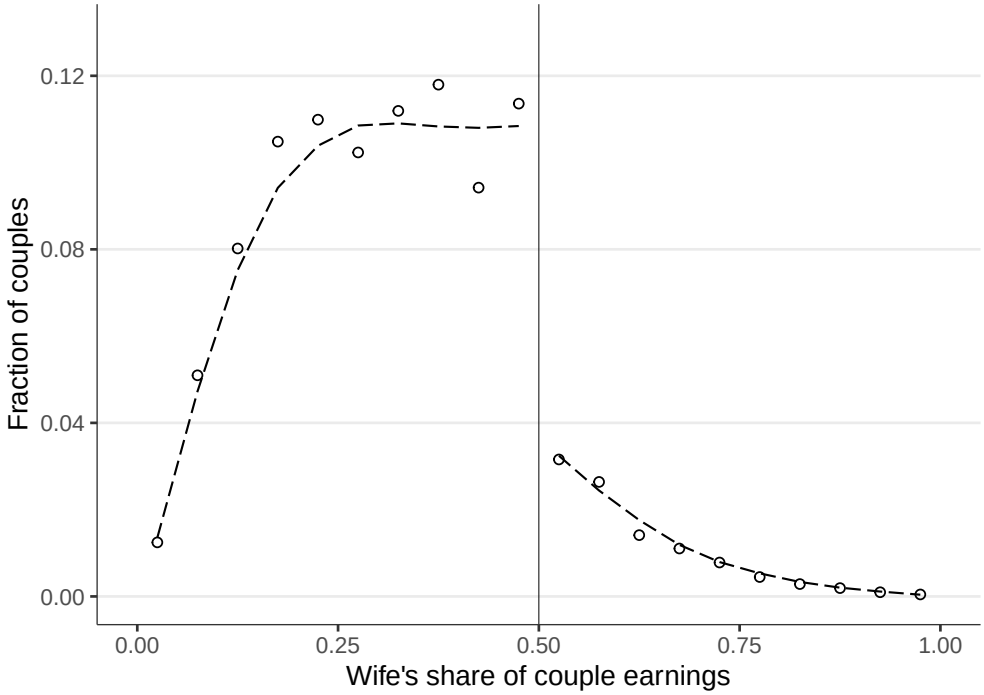


Figure 1: Wife's share of household earnings across India.

Notes: The plot shows the distribution of the wife's share of couple earnings ($\frac{\text{wife earnings}}{\text{husband earnings + wife earnings}}$) across India, using data from the PLFS between 2021 and 2024. Each dot shows the fraction of couples in a 0.05 relative income bin. Couples where both spouses earn exactly the same amount are in the bin ending at 0.5. The dashed lines are lowess fits, estimated separately on each side of 0.5, and the solid line marks 0.5.

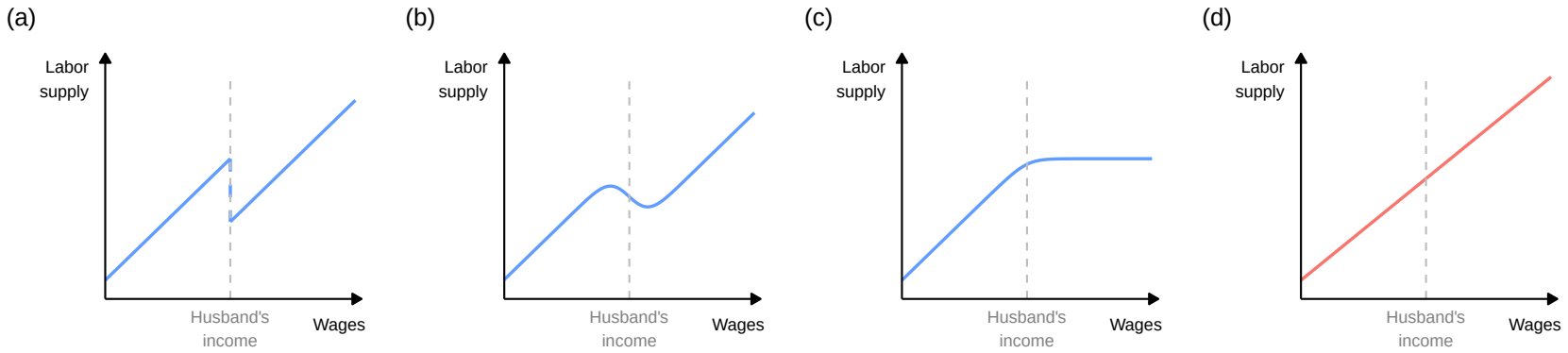


Figure 2: Potential inverse labor supply curves.

Notes: The four panels show possible inverse labor supply curves. Panels (a)–(c) show inverse labor supply curves under different models of breadwinning norms. Panel (a) shows a discontinuous drop in labor supply at the husband's income, which could arise if the household incurs a fixed cost from violating the norm. Panel (b) shows a change in the elasticity of labor supply around the husband's income, which could arise if the couple faces income uncertainty, or if the husband's income is mismeasured. Panel (c) shows a change in the elasticity of labor supply above the husband's income, which could arise if violating the norm becomes increasingly costly the more the wife outearns her husband. Our experimental design allows us to test for all these variants of breadwinning norms. Panel (d) shows the inverse labor supply curve under a standard model, which is smooth and upward sloping with no change in elasticity or discontinuity around the husband's income.

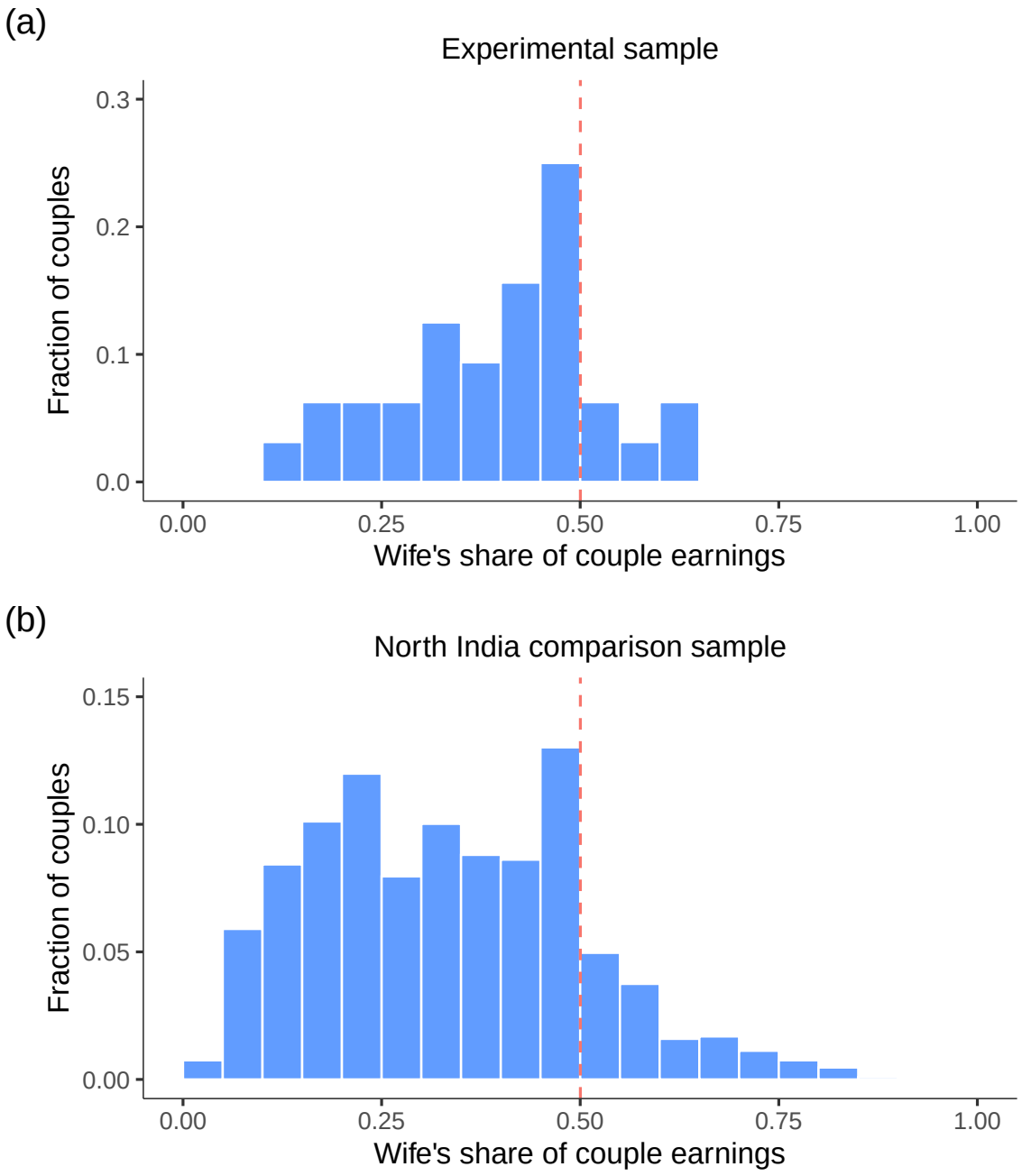


Figure 3: Wife's share of household earnings in experimental and representative samples.

Notes: Panel (a) shows our experimental sample. We restrict to households where both partners are working. The bars show the fraction of households within 0.05 relative income bins. Panel (b) shows a representative comparison sample using data from the PLFS (2021-2024) that restricts to married women aged 18–32 who have completed 12th grade in North India (Bihar, Chandigarh, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand), where both partners are working. Couples where both spouses earn exactly the same amount are in the bin ending at 0.5. The red dashed line marks a relative income share of 0.5.

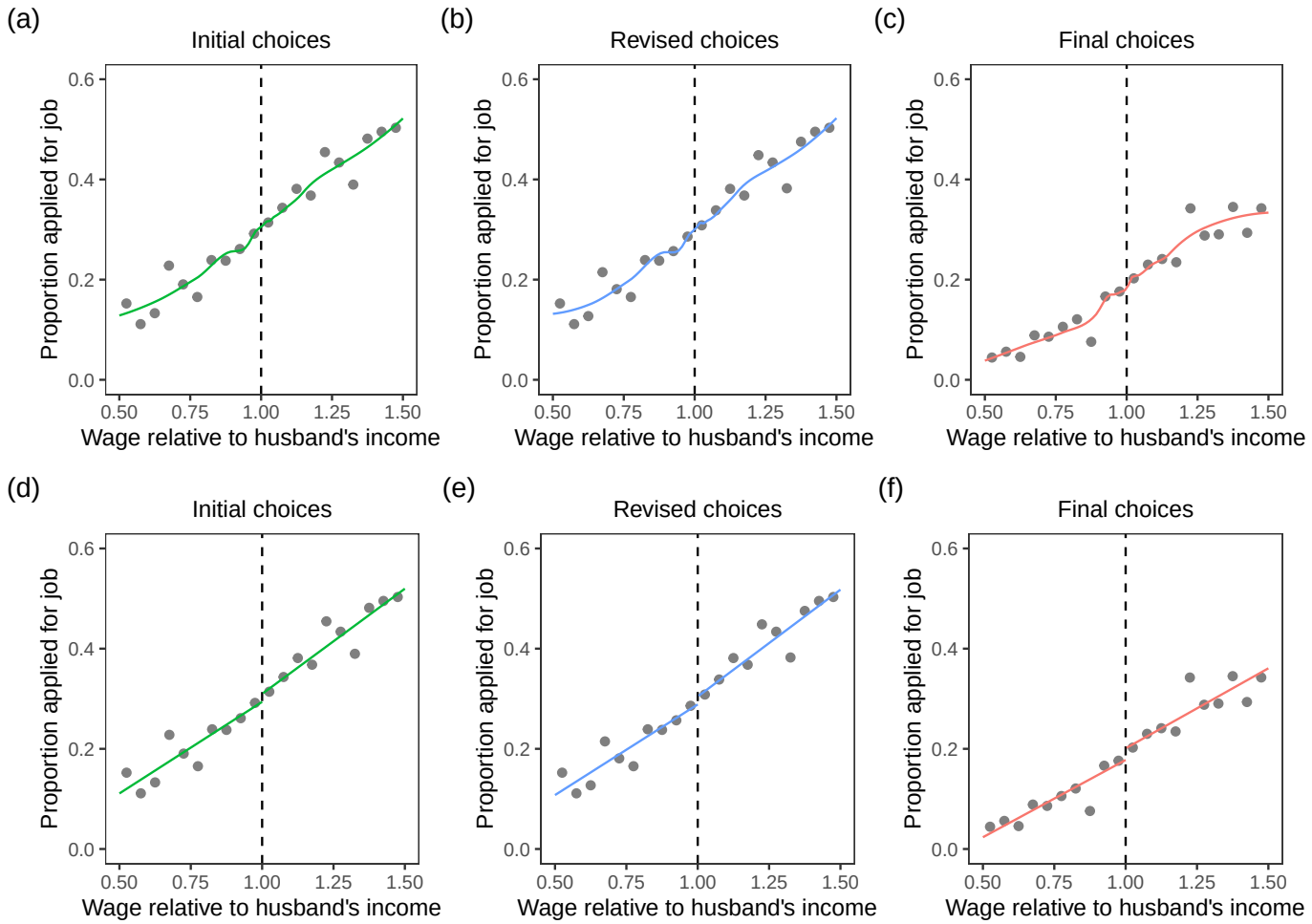


Figure 4: Inverse labor supply curves at different stages in the decision-making process.

Notes: Each panel plots the proportion of participants who apply for a job at a given wage offer relative to their husband's income. The gray points are mean application rates within 0.05 width bins. Panels (a)–(c) fit a local polynomial regression to the data; panels (d)–(f) fit a piecewise linear regression to the data (allowing for a change in intercept and slope above/below the husband's income). Panels (a) and (d) use participants' *initial* application choices, panels (b) and (e) their *revised* application choices after a subset were informed that their application decisions would be shared with their husbands, and panels (c) and (f) their *final* application choices.

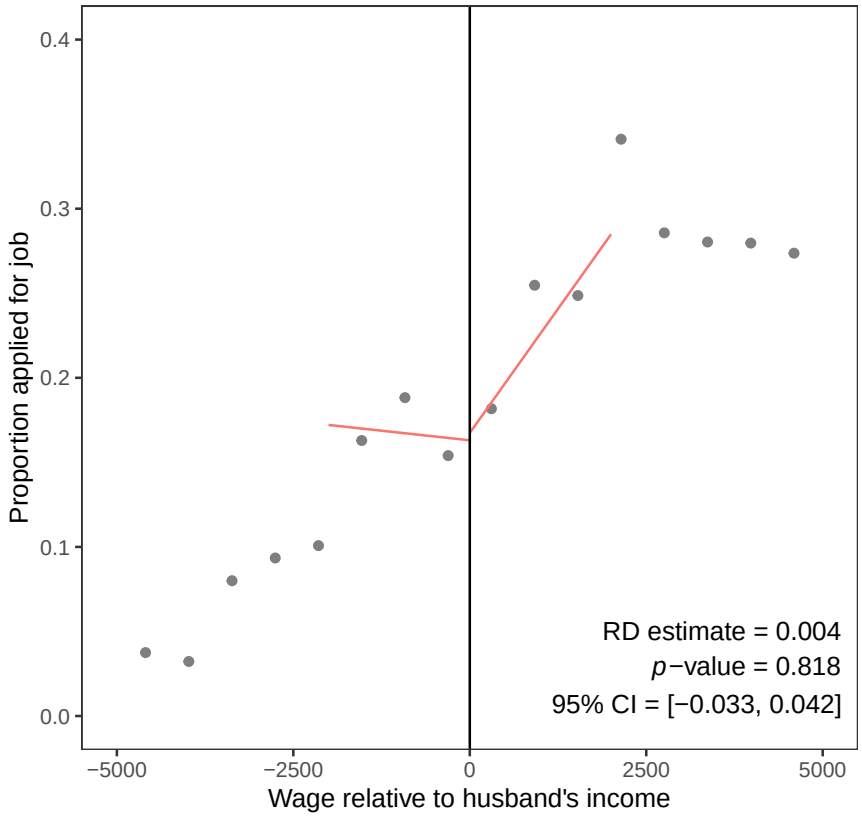


Figure 5: Test for discontinuity in married women's labor supply.

Notes: The figure shows a regression discontinuity plot of women's *final* job application choices against the relative wage offer in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). The gray points are binned means and the lines are local linear regressions on either side of the husband's income. As pre-registered, we use a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees, restrict to households where the husband earns at least 4,000 rupees, and include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. The bottom-right corner reports the RD estimate from this specification along with its p-value and 95% confidence interval using robust standard errors.

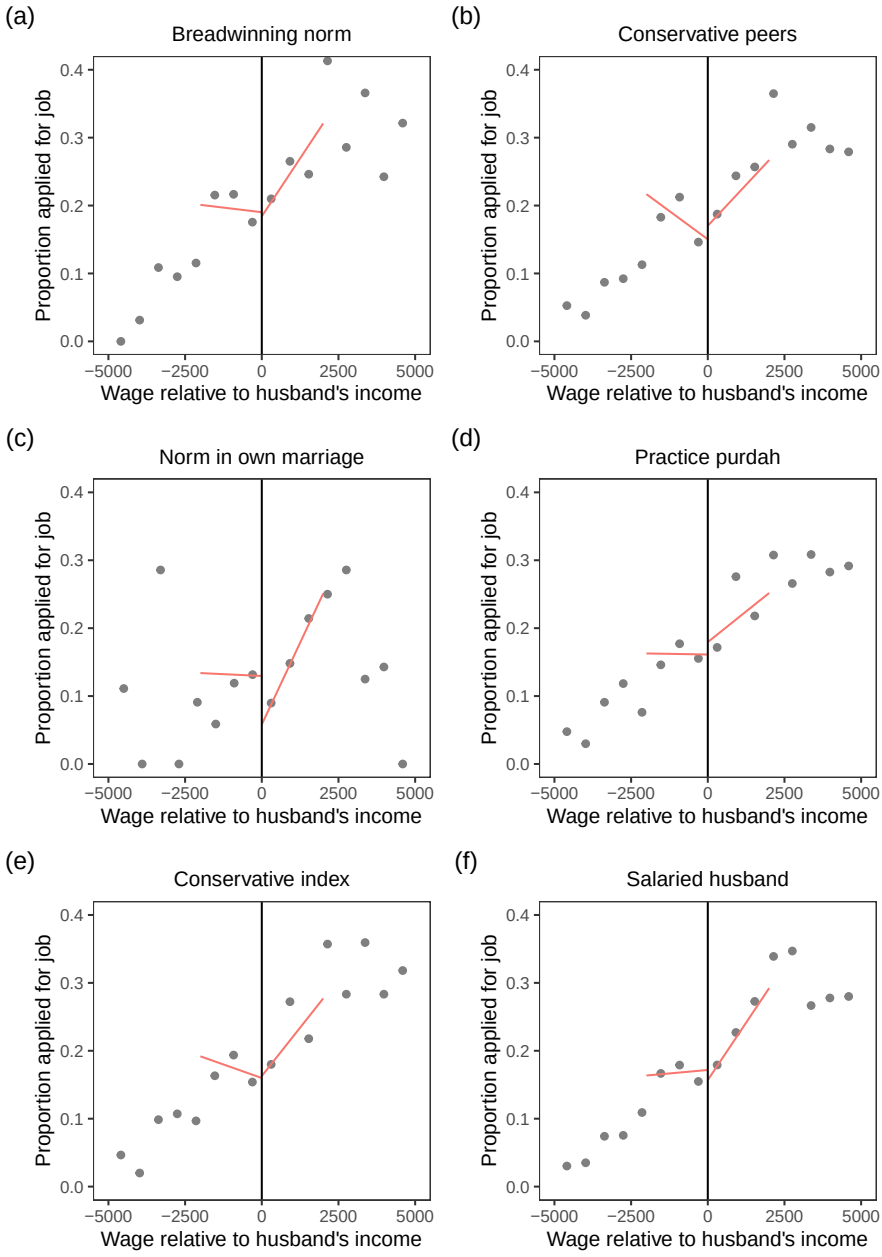


Figure 6: RD plots in subsamples where breadwinning norms may be strongest.

Notes: Each panel shows a regression discontinuity plot of women's final job application choices on the relative wage offer in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). The gray points are binned means and the lines are local linear regressions on either side of the husband's income. We show results for subsamples where breadwinning norms could be most important: (a) above-median agreement with breadwinning norms; (b) above-median in the number of peers agreeing with the norm; (c) above-median in agreement that the norm applies in their own marriage; (d) women who practice purdah; (e) above-median on a standardized index of measures (a)–(d); and (f) participants whose husbands hold a salaried job. Across all panels, we use a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees, triangular kernel weights, restrict to households where the husband earns at least 4,000 rupees, and include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls (as pre-registered).

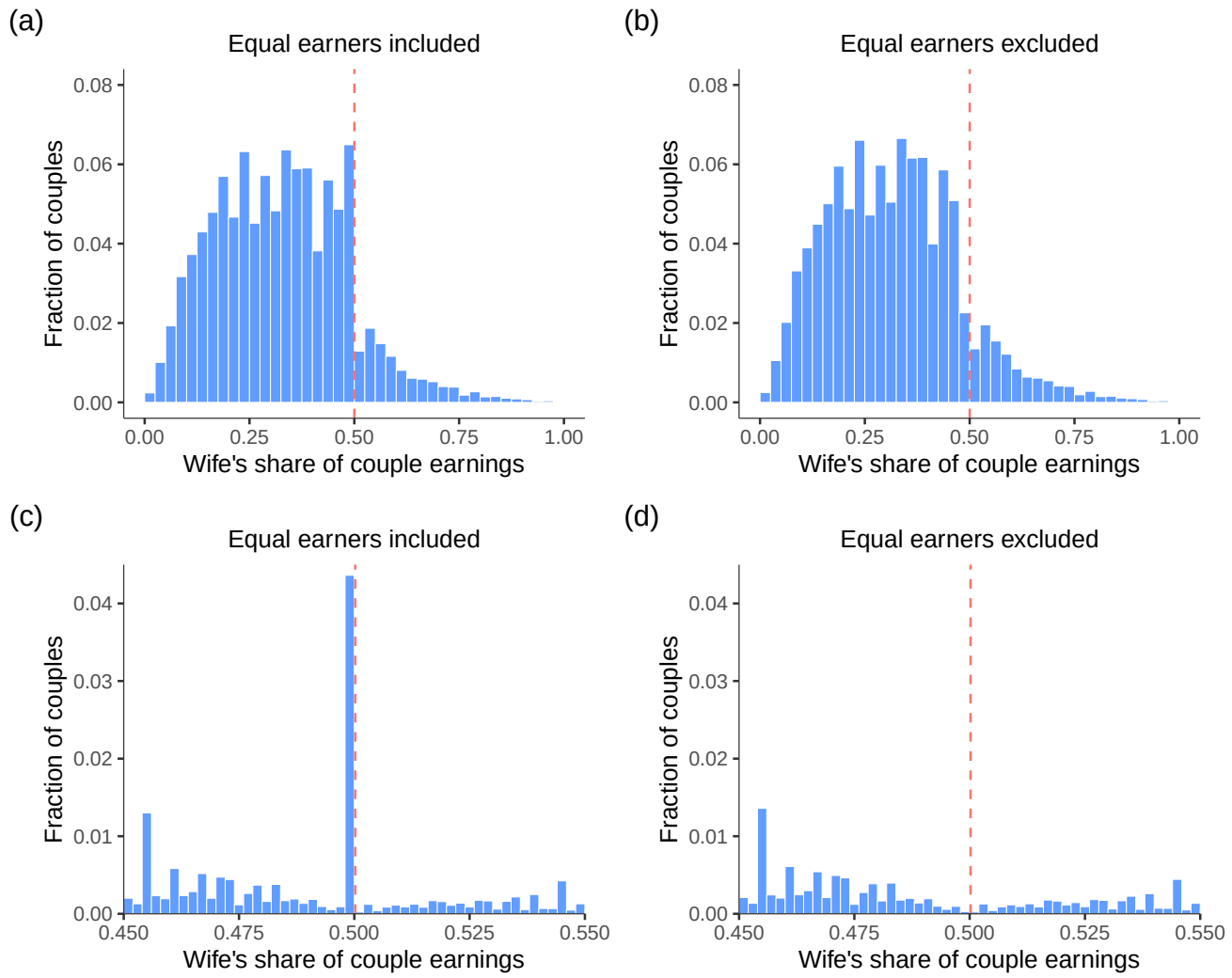


Figure 7: Distribution of the wife's share of earnings.

Notes: The plot shows the distribution of the wife's share of couple earnings ($\frac{\text{wife earnings}}{\text{husband earnings} + \text{wife earnings}}$) across India, using data from the PLFS between 2021 and 2024. In panels (a) and (b), the bars show the fraction of couples in each 0.025 relative income bin. Panels (c) and (d) show shares between 0.45 and 0.55, with bars showing the fraction of all couples in each 0.002 relative income bin. In panels (a) and (c), couples where both spouses earn exactly the same amount are in the bin ending at 0.5; panels (b) and (d) exclude these couples. The red dashed line marks 0.5.

Tables

Table 1: Sample characteristics.

	Mean	Std. dev	N
Panel A: Demographics			
Age	26.80	5.50	171
Number of children	1.01	0.92	171
Has children	0.65	0.48	171
Hindu	0.90	0.30	171
Finished 12th grade	0.89	0.32	171
Finished college	0.51	0.50	171
Employed	0.19	0.39	171
Lives with in-laws	0.80	0.40	171
Working at time of marriage	0.35	0.48	148
Worked since marriage	0.52	0.50	148
Years married	6.65	6.67	147
Monthly wage (₹1,000s, if working)	10.36	5.86	32
Wife's share of couple earnings (if working)	0.40	0.13	32
Husband's age	30.12	6.63	171
Husband finished 12th grade	0.64	0.48	171
Husband finished college	0.37	0.48	171
Husband employed	1.00	0.00	171
Husband salaried	0.44	0.50	171
Husband's monthly wage (₹1,000s)	14.46	5.92	171
Panel B: Attitudes and norms			
Agree with breadwinning norm	0.30	0.46	148
Prop. of peers agree with norm	0.48	0.34	148
Agree with norm in own marriage	0.07	0.26	148
Practices purdah (veiling)	0.76	0.43	148
Husband has most say over her work	0.64	0.48	148
Husband or in-laws have most say over her work	0.72	0.45	148
Husband refuses to leave call	0.51	0.50	112
Husband knows her exact earnings	1.00	0.00	28

Notes: The columns show each variable's sample mean, standard deviation, and number of observations. "Agree with breadwinning norm" indicates the wife's agreement with the statement "If a woman earns more money than her husband it's almost certain to cause problems"; "Prop. of peers agree with norm" is the share of the wife's 10 closest friends and family who she believes would agree with the same statement; "Agree with norm in own marriage" indicates the wife reporting it would cause problems in her own marriage if she earned more than her husband; "Husband has most say over her work" indicates the wife stating her husband has the most say in decisions about her job; "Husband refuses to leave call" indicates the husband staying on the call after being told he can leave (recorded at six of eight training centers); and "Husband knows her exact earnings" indicates the husband knows exactly how much the wife earns (if she is currently working). Rows with N=171 were collected in the first survey; rows with N=148 were collected in the third survey.

Table 2: Estimates of discontinuities and labor supply elasticities near the husband's income.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: Regression Discontinuity			
RD Estimate	0.024	0.004	-0.014
	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.018)
	[-0.022,0.071]	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.049,0.021]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.302	0.818	0.444
Observations	2536	3198	3515
Panel B: Slope			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.625**	0.243	0.367***
	(0.292)	(0.148)	(0.082)
	[0.052,1.20]	[-0.047,0.53]	[0.21,0.53]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.033	0.101	0.000
Observations	2060	2880	3385
Panel C: Difference in Means			
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.032**	0.044***	0.065***
	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.012)
	[0.0039,0.059]	[0.020,0.069]	[0.043,0.088]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.166	0.161	0.155
p-value	0.025	0.000	0.000
Observations	2536	3198	3575

Notes: Panel A reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for bandwidths of 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2000, 4000, and 6000 rupees respectively (as pre-registered). Panel B shows slope estimates of labor supply on relative wages in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$) around the husband's income. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. Panel C shows estimates of changes in labor supply for job offers slightly above the husband's income relative to offers slightly below the husband's income. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for offers 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 3: Test for breadwinning norms under alternative cutoff definitions, both with and without controls.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)								
	Equal offers on left			Equal offers excluded			Equal offers on right		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)
Panel A: With Controls									
RD Estimate	0.024	0.004	-0.014	0.050*	0.015	-0.009	0.059**	0.023	-0.002
	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.018)	(0.026)	(0.020)	(0.019)	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.018)
	[-0.022,0.071]	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.049,0.021]	[-0.0014,0.10]	[-0.025,0.055]	[-0.046,0.028]	[0.012,0.11]	[-0.015,0.060]	[-0.037,0.032]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.302	0.818	0.444	0.056	0.467	0.629	0.013	0.233	0.891
Observations	2536	3198	3515	2342	3004	3328	2536	3198	3515
Panel B: Without Controls									
RD Estimate	0.014	0.006	-0.012	0.025	0.007	-0.012	0.026	0.006	-0.011
	(0.031)	(0.024)	(0.023)	(0.035)	(0.026)	(0.024)	(0.031)	(0.024)	(0.022)
	[-0.047,0.075]	[-0.041,0.054]	[-0.056,0.033]	[-0.043,0.094]	[-0.043,0.058]	[-0.059,0.034]	[-0.036,0.087]	[-0.040,0.053]	[-0.055,0.032]
Controls	No	No	No	No	No	No	No	No	No
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.652	0.792	0.608	0.468	0.779	0.600	0.414	0.791	0.615
Observations	2536	3198	3515	2342	3004	3328	2536	3198	3515

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply under different definitions of the cutoff. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). Columns (1)–(3) place offers exactly equal to the husband's income below the cutoff (our main specification); columns (4)–(6) exclude such offers from the analysis; and columns (7)–(9) place them above the cutoff. Within each definition, the three columns show bandwidths of 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2000, 4000, and 6000 rupees respectively (as pre-registered). We estimate local linear regressions with triangular kernel weights. Panel A controls for individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job; Panel B includes no controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 4: Test for breadwinning norms in conservative and salaried subsamples.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)						
	Breadwinning norm	Conservative peers	Norm in own marriage	Purdah	Conservative index	Salaried husband	Controlling husband
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Panel A: Equal offers on left							
RD Estimate	-0.006	0.020	-0.071*	0.018	0.003	-0.015	-0.008
	(0.029)	(0.024)	(0.040)	(0.021)	(0.024)	(0.027)	(0.031)
	[-0.064,0.052]	[-0.027,0.067]	[-0.15,0.0078]	[-0.024,0.060]	[-0.044,0.049]	[-0.069,0.039]	[-0.069,0.053]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.837	0.410	0.077	0.392	0.903	0.587	0.793
Observations	1188	1834	266	2315	1790	1423	1113
Panel B: Equal offers on right							
RD Estimate	0.016	0.016	0.005	0.021	0.000	0.031	0.000
	(0.030)	(0.024)	(0.044)	(0.022)	(0.024)	(0.027)	(0.031)
	[-0.044,0.075]	[-0.032,0.063]	[-0.081,0.091]	[-0.022,0.064]	[-0.048,0.048]	[-0.022,0.085]	[-0.060,0.060]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.608	0.514	0.912	0.333	1.000	0.249	0.993
Observations	1188	1834	266	2315	1790	1423	1113

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply in a given subsample. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights and a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees on either side of the cutoff, and drop households in which the husband earns less than 4,000 rupees (as pre-registered). Panel A assigns offers exactly equal to the husband's income to the left of the cutoff (our main specification); Panel B assigns them to the right of the cutoff. We show results for subsamples where breadwinning norms could be most important: (1) above-median agreement with breadwinning norms; (2) above-median in the number of peers agreeing with the norm; (3) above-median in agreement that the norm applies in their own marriage; (4) women who practice purdah; (5) above-median on a standardized index of measures (1)–(4); (6) participants whose husbands hold a salaried job; and (7) households in which the husband refused to leave the call between the surveyor and his wife (recorded at six of eight training centers). All columns include individual fixed effects and job fixed effects, and control for distance to the job. We report point estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), 95% confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 5: Labor supply elasticity.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Log wage offer	0.336***	0.322***	0.323***
	(0.022)	(0.022)	(0.022)
	[0.29,0.38]	[0.28,0.36]	[0.28,0.37]
Individual FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Job FE	No	Yes	Yes
Distance controls	No	No	Yes
Mean application rate	0.191	0.191	0.191
LS Elasticity	1.75	1.68	1.69
p-value	0.000	0.000	0.000
Observations	4834	4834	4834

Notes: Each column regresses job applications on the log of the wage offer, using participants' final job application decisions. Column (1) includes individual fixed effects; column (2) adds job fixed effects; and column (3) adds distance to the job. We calculate the implied labor supply elasticity by dividing the estimate by the mean application rate. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table 6: Relative income and wife's employment 13 months later.

	Dependent variable: Wife employed 13 months later (=1)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Wife earns more	-0.002	-0.003	-0.005	-0.005
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.009)	(0.009)
	[-0.018,0.014]	[-0.019,0.013]	[-0.023,0.013]	[-0.023,0.013]
Couple and month FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Absolute income controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Additional FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes
Demographic controls	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	2,283,067	2,283,067	2,283,067	2,283,067

Notes: Each column regresses an indicator for the wife being employed on an indicator for the wife earning strictly more than her husband in the previous period, controlling for indicators for only the wife earning, only the husband earning, and neither spouse earning, the wife's share of couple income (allowing for a different slope above and below one half), and couple and month fixed effects. Column (1) estimates Equation 5. We use couple-level panel data from the Consumer Pyramids Household Survey (CPHS) from 2015 to 2025. See Appendix C.1 for details on the sample construction. Earnings are each spouse's wage income in a given month, and employment is measured at the household visit 13 months later. Column (2) adds log couple income; column (3) interacts the couple and month fixed effects with indicators for only the wife earning, only the husband earning, and neither spouse earning in the previous period; and column (4) adds quadratics in the wife's and husband's ages and an indicator for having children. We display the estimates, standard errors clustered by couple (in parentheses), and confidence intervals (in brackets). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

A Appendix Figures



Figure A.1: Locations of the eight Pratham vocational training centers in the study.

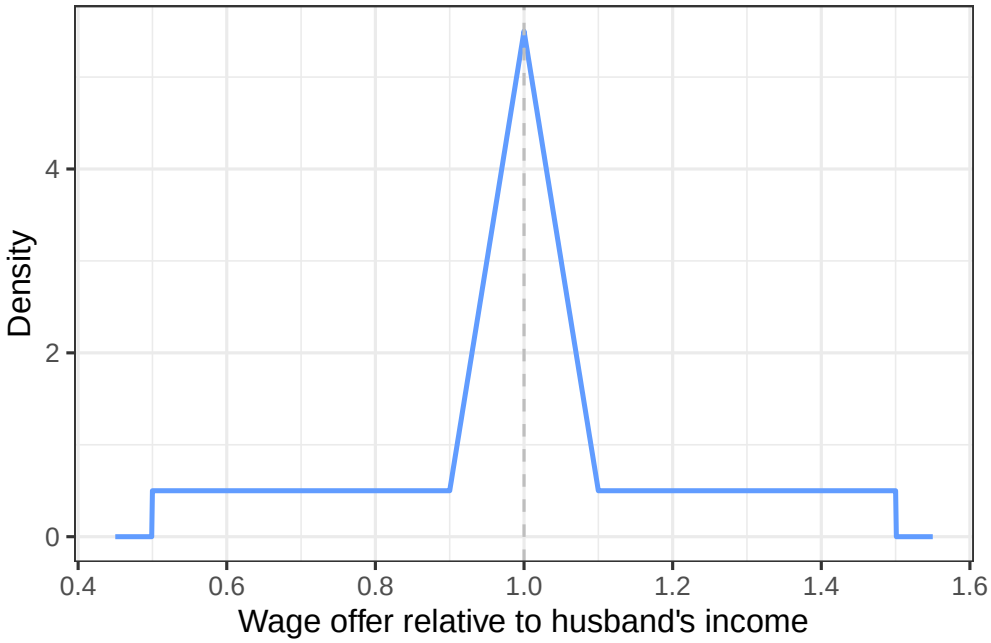


Figure A.2: Probability density function of randomized wage offers.

Notes: Wage offers for the hypothetical jobs are drawn with 50 percent probability from one of two distributions. The first, a uniform distribution between 0.5 and 1.5 times the husband's income, and second, a triangular distribution between 0.9 and 1.1 times the husband's income. The figure plots the resulting probability density function of the wage offer relative to the husband's income. We round these wage offers to the nearest 100 rupees. The dashed line marks parity with the husband's income.

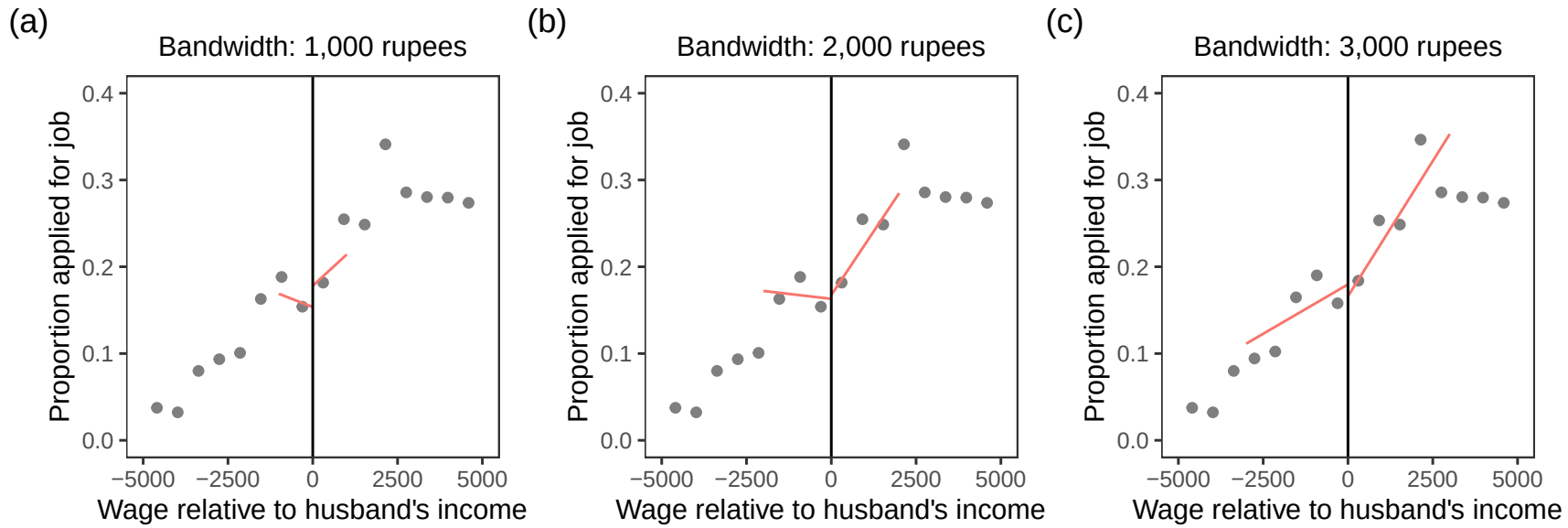


Figure A.3: RD plots of labor supply around the husband's income at pre-registered bandwidths.

Notes: Each panel plots the proportion of participants interested in a job against the wage offer relative to the husband's income, using participants' final choices and the main specification: a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights on either side of the cutoff, controlling for individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job, weighted by the inverse probability weights. Panels (a), (b), and (c) use bandwidths of 1,000, 2,000, and 3,000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2,000, 4,000, and 6,000 rupees respectively.



Figure A.4: RD plots of labor supply around the husband's income across decision stages.

Notes: Each panel plots the proportion of participants interested in a job against the wage offer relative to the husband's income, using the main specification: a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights and a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees on either side of the cutoff, dropping households where the husband's wage is less than 4,000 rupees (as pre-registered), controlling for individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job, and weighted by the pre-registered inverse probability weights. Panel (a) uses participants' *initial* job application choices, panel (b) their *revised* job application choices after a subset were informed that their choices would be shared with their husbands, and panel (c) their *final* job application choices, after having time to discuss the jobs with their husband and family.

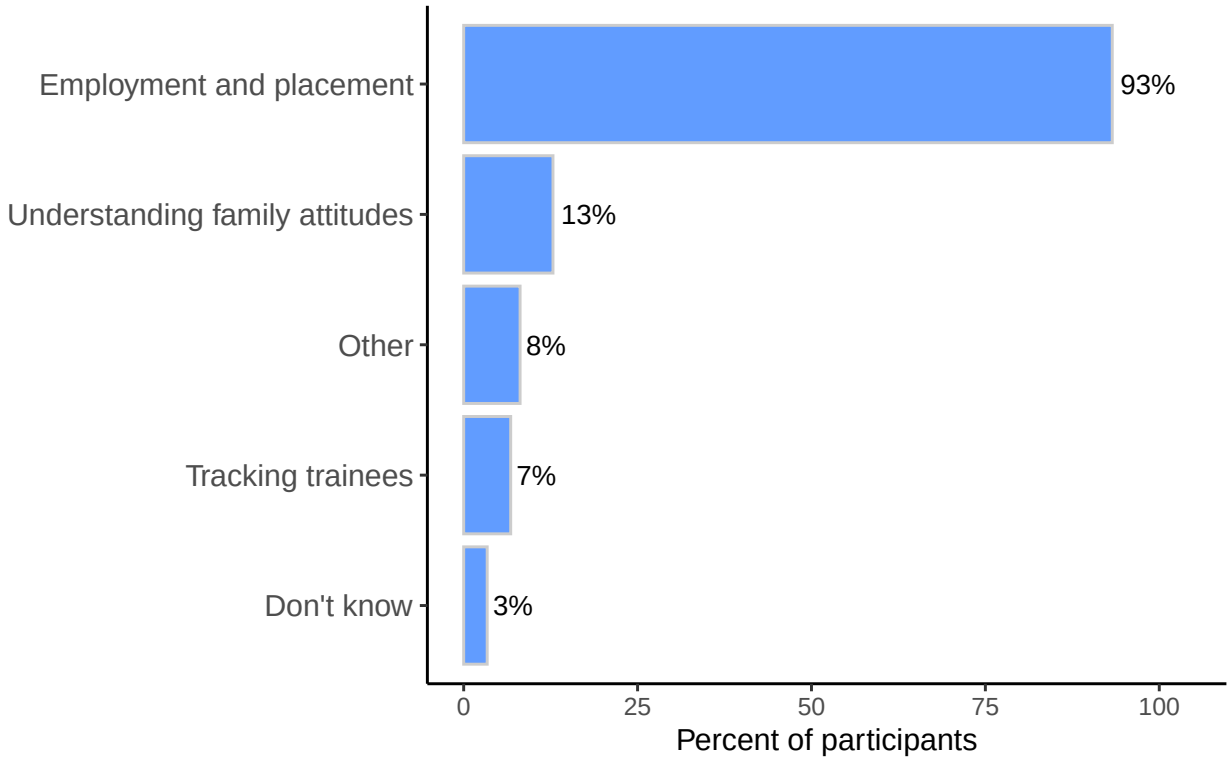


Figure A.5: What participants thought the survey was about.

Notes: At the end of Survey 3, participants were asked an open-ended question about what they thought the survey was about. The question was asked at the end of the final survey, shortly after questions on gender attitudes and who has most say about their labor market decisions. The bars do not sum to 1 given a participant can mention multiple reasons. None of the participants mentioned anything related to relative income comparisons within the household.

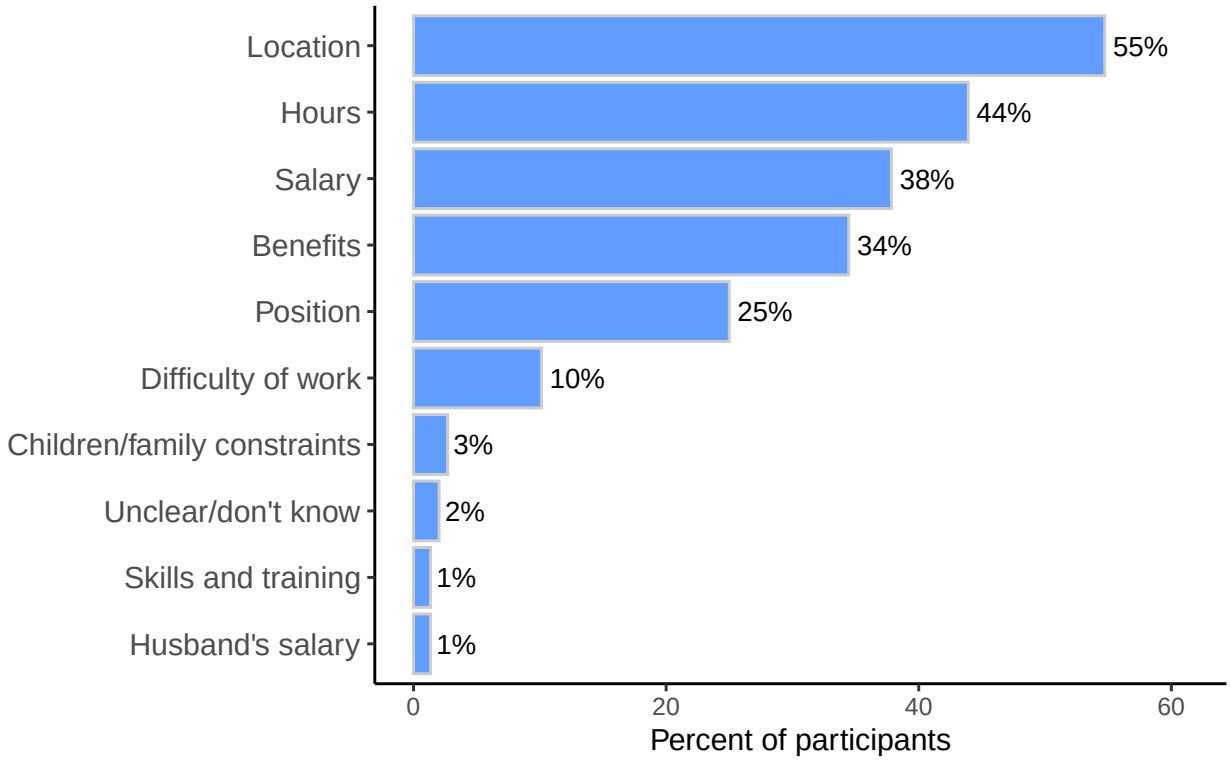


Figure A.6: What participants considered when deciding which jobs to apply for.

Notes: At the end of Survey 3, participants were asked an open-ended question about what their major considerations were when deciding which jobs to apply for. Participants can voice multiple considerations. The two participants who mentioned their husband's salary talked about their husband's salary being low and unstable, and did not mention any concern related to outearning their husband.

B Appendix Tables

Table A.1: Recruitment and selection into the experiment.

	Number	Percent (%)
Unmarried	3392	85.5
Wife declined	229	5.8
Husband declined	38	1.0
Survey 1 started	310	7.8
Total	3969	100.0

Notes: The table shows the outcome of all households where we were able to connect with a female graduate of the training program. "Unmarried" includes women who confirmed they were unmarried on the call (2585 women) and women who immediately declined the survey and were unmarried when they completed their training (807 women). "Wife declined" are participants who immediately declined the survey and were married at the time of training. "Survey 1 started" are all participants who started the first survey (117 were already married when they completed their training, and 193 were unmarried when they completed their training).

Table A.2: Breadwinning norms test: subsamples with precisely measured husband's income.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)			
	Main specification (1)	Salaried husband (2)	Quoted single number (3)	Reported true salary (4)
RD Estimate	0.004	-0.015	-0.006	0.013
	(0.019)	(0.027)	(0.023)	(0.020)
	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.069,0.039]	[-0.050,0.039]	[-0.025,0.052]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.818	0.587	0.808	0.500
Observations	3198	1423	2188	2879

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply, on subsamples where the husband's income is measured with more certainty. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate local linear regressions with triangular kernel weights, using our main specification: a bandwidth of 2000 rupees above or below the husband's income, dropping households where the husband's wage is less than 4000 rupees, and including controls for individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job (as pre-registered). Column (1) uses the full main sample. Column (2) restricts to husbands whose income does not vary month to month (salaried). Column (3) restricts to husbands who quoted their salary as a single number, rather than a range. Column (4) restricts to participants who confirmed at the end of the study that our measure of the husband's income was accurate. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.3: Breadwinning norms test: subsamples where husband's wage is within the support of real job offers.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: Regression Discontinuity			
RD Estimate	0.057**	0.007	-0.023
	(0.026)	(0.021)	(0.021)
	[0.0066,0.11]	[-0.035,0.050]	[-0.063,0.017]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.027	0.730	0.266
Observations	1660	1983	2192
Panel B: Slope			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.688*	0.163	0.344***
	(0.390)	(0.190)	(0.109)
	[-0.078,1.45]	[-0.21,0.54]	[0.13,0.56]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.078	0.390	0.002
Observations	1208	1701	1980
Panel C: Difference in Means			
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.034**	0.047***	0.080***
	(0.017)	(0.016)	(0.015)
	[0.00034,0.067]	[0.017,0.078]	[0.051,0.11]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.141	0.135	0.130
p-value	0.048	0.002	0.000
Observations	1660	1983	2222

Notes: This table replicates Table 2 for the subsample of participants whose husband's income lies within the span of the real jobs' salaries at their vocational training center. Panel A reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for bandwidths of 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2000, 4000, and 6000 rupees respectively (as pre-registered). Panel B shows slope estimates of labor supply on relative wages in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$) around the husband's income. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. Panel C shows estimates of changes in labor supply for job offers slightly above the husband's income relative to offers slightly below the husband's income. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for offers 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.4: Final placement outcomes.

	Number	Percent (%)
Found another job before placement	3	25.0
Started job	2	16.7
Turned down job		
Distance too far	2	16.7
Pregnancy	2	16.7
No longer interested	2	16.7
Family didn't allow	1	8.3
Total	12	100.0

Notes: Final placement outcomes for participants who were matched to a job after implementing the placement mechanism. Most participants did not apply for the job choice that was randomly selected to be implemented and as such are not included in this table.

Table A.5: Attrition and sample selection in Survey 1.

	Number	Percent (%)
Dropped out before jobs section	57	18.4
Dropped out during or after jobs section	17	5.5
Husband not employed	19	6.1
Husband refused to provide wage	5	1.6
Wife not interested in jobs	3	1.0
Husband's wages too high or low	15	4.8
Rejected all hypothetical jobs	23	7.4
Experimental sample (Survey 1)	171	55.2
Total	310	100.0

Notes: The table summarizes the outcome of all participants who started the first survey.

Table A.6: Estimates of discontinuities and labor supply elasticities near the husband's income, with standard errors clustered at the individual level.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: Regression Discontinuity			
RD Estimate	0.024	0.004	-0.014
	(0.021)	(0.017)	(0.017)
	[-0.017,0.066]	[-0.029,0.038]	[-0.047,0.019]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.250	0.797	0.418
Observations	2536	3198	3515
Panel B: Slope			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.625**	0.243	0.367***
	(0.257)	(0.149)	(0.090)
	[0.12,1.13]	[-0.051,0.54]	[0.19,0.54]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.016	0.105	0.000
Observations	2060	2880	3385
Panel C: Difference in Means			
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.032**	0.044***	0.065***
	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.011)
	[0.0033,0.060]	[0.020,0.069]	[0.043,0.088]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.166	0.161	0.155
p-value	0.029	0.000	0.000
Observations	2536	3198	3575

Notes: This table replicates Table 2 with standard errors clustered at the individual level. Panel A reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for bandwidths of 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2000, 4000, and 6000 rupees respectively (as pre-registered). Panel B shows slope estimates of labor supply on relative wages in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$) around the husband's income. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. Panel C shows estimates of changes in labor supply for job offers slightly above the husband's income relative to offers slightly below the husband's income. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for offers 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, standard errors clustered by participant (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.7: Breadwinning norms test with and without inverse probability weights (IPW).

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: With IPW			
RD Estimate	0.024	0.004	-0.014
	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.018)
	[-0.022,0.071]	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.049,0.021]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.302	0.818	0.444
Observations	2536	3198	3515
Panel B: Without IPW			
RD Estimate	0.032	0.017	0.005
	(0.022)	(0.018)	(0.016)
	[-0.011,0.076]	[-0.018,0.052]	[-0.027,0.037]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.146	0.336	0.755
Observations	2536	3198	3515

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate local linear regressions with triangular kernel weights. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for bandwidths of 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2000, 4000, and 6000 rupees respectively (as pre-registered). Panel A weights observations by inverse probability weights that adjust for the rounding of wage offers to the nearest 100 rupees; Panel B repeats the estimation without the weights. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.8: Comparison of sample to broader population.

	Study sample			Comparison population		
	Mean	Std. dev	N	Mean	Std. dev	N
Panel A: Demographics						
Age	26.80	5.50	171	26.87	3.41	3975
Number of children	1.01	0.92	171	1.24	0.94	3975
Has children	0.65	0.48	171	0.75	0.43	3975
Hindu	0.90	0.30	171	0.88	0.33	3975
Finished 12th grade	0.89	0.32	171	1.00	0.00	3975
Finished college	0.51	0.50	171	0.51	0.50	3975
Employed	0.19	0.39	171	0.10	0.29	3975
Lives with in-laws	0.80	0.40	171	0.70	0.46	3975
Monthly wage (₹1,000s, if working)	10.36	5.86	32	15.30	26.47	464
Husband's age	30.12	6.63	171	30.20	4.07	3975
Husband finished 12th grade	0.64	0.48	171	0.73	0.44	3975
Husband finished college	0.37	0.48	171	0.49	0.50	3975
Husband employed	1.00	0.00	171	0.78	0.41	3975
Husband salaried	0.44	0.50	171	0.35	0.48	3975
Husband's monthly wage (₹1,000s)	14.46	5.92	171	20.03	16.43	3209
Wife's share of couple earnings (if working)	0.40	0.13	32	0.34	0.18	401
Panel B: Attitudes and norms						
Practices purdah (veiling)	0.76	0.43	148	0.73	0.44	1095
Husband has most say over her work	0.64	0.48	148	0.46	0.50	869
Husband or in-laws have most say over her work	0.72	0.45	148	0.56	0.50	869

Notes: The study sample columns report statistics for our experimental sample. The comparison population columns report statistics for married women, aged 18–32 who have completed 12th grade in North India (Bihar, Chandigarh, Chhattisgarh, Delhi, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand). In Panel A, data for the comparison population come from the PLFS (July 2023–June 2024). In Panel B, data for the comparison population come from the IHDS-II (2011–12).

Table A.9: Breadwinning norms test at each decision stage.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: Initial Choices			
RD Estimate	0.019	0.006	0.002
	(0.026)	(0.021)	(0.020)
	[-0.033,0.070]	[-0.035,0.048]	[-0.037,0.040]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.475	0.767	0.924
Observations	2799	3491	3842
Panel B: Revised Choices			
RD Estimate	0.026	0.009	0.002
	(0.026)	(0.021)	(0.020)
	[-0.025,0.077]	[-0.033,0.050]	[-0.037,0.040]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.323	0.682	0.936
Observations	2799	3491	3842
Panel C: Final Choices			
RD Estimate	0.024	0.004	-0.014
	(0.024)	(0.019)	(0.018)
	[-0.022,0.071]	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.049,0.021]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
p-value	0.302	0.818	0.444
Observations	2536	3198	3515

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for bandwidths of 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively, and drop households where the husband's wage is less than 2000, 4000, and 6000 rupees respectively (as pre-registered). Panel A uses participants' *initial* job application choices, their choices the first time they are read the job descriptions; Panel B their *revised* job application choices, after a subset were informed that their choices would be shared with their husbands; and Panel C their *final* job application choices, after having time to discuss the jobs with their husband and family. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.10: Breadwinning norms by husband's presence.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)	
	Husband joined via conference call (1)	Husband present with wife (2)
RD Estimate	0.016	0.014
	(0.031)	(0.022)
	[-0.044,0.076]	[-0.030,0.057]
Controls	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.607	0.535
Observations	1013	2185

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply, estimated separately on the indicated subsample using our pre-registered main specification: a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights and a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees on either side of the cutoff, dropping households where the husband's wage is less than 4,000 rupees, with individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job as controls. Column (1) restricts to participants whose husbands joined the first survey remotely by conference call; column (2) to participants whose husbands were physically present alongside them for the first survey, and joined by putting the call on speakerphone. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.11: Slope test for breadwinning norms at each decision stage.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: Initial Choices			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.470	0.335**	0.386***
	(0.322)	(0.159)	(0.092)
	[-0.16,1.10]	[0.022,0.65]	[0.21,0.57]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.144	0.036	0.000
Observations	2264	3168	3723
Panel B: Revised Choices			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.429	0.334**	0.390***
	(0.318)	(0.158)	(0.092)
	[-0.19,1.05]	[0.024,0.64]	[0.21,0.57]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.177	0.035	0.000
Observations	2264	3168	3723
Panel C: Final Choices			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.625**	0.243	0.367***
	(0.292)	(0.148)	(0.082)
	[0.052,1.20]	[-0.047,0.53]	[0.21,0.53]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.033	0.101	0.000
Observations	2060	2880	3385

Notes: Each column regresses labor supply on the relative wage offer in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$). Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. Panel A uses participants' *initial* job application choices, their choices the first time they are read the job descriptions; Panel B their *revised* job application choices, after a subset were informed that their choices would be shared with their husbands; and Panel C their *final* job application choices, after having time to discuss the jobs with their husband and family. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.12: Slope test for breadwinning norms with and without controls.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: With Controls			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.625**	0.243	0.367***
	(0.292)	(0.148)	(0.082)
	[0.052,1.20]	[-0.047,0.53]	[0.21,0.53]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.033	0.101	0.000
Observations	2060	2880	3385
Panel B: Without Controls			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.494	0.406**	0.400***
	(0.313)	(0.165)	(0.089)
	[-0.12,1.11]	[0.083,0.73]	[0.22,0.57]
Controls	No	No	No
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value	0.115	0.014	0.000
Observations	2060	2880	3385

Notes: Each column regresses labor supply on the relative wage offer in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$). Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. In Panel A, we include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. In Panel B, we do not include controls or fixed effects. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.13: Difference in means test for breadwinning norms at each decision stage.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: Initial Choices				
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.029	0.031**	0.047***	0.063***
	(0.019)	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.013)
	[-0.0088,0.066]	[0.00063,0.061]	[0.020,0.074]	[0.038,0.088]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-500, 500]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.271	0.272	0.270	0.264
p-value	0.134	0.045	0.001	0.000
Observations	1945	2799	3521	3932
Panel B: Revised Choices				
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.033*	0.033**	0.047***	0.063***
	(0.019)	(0.015)	(0.013)	(0.013)
	[-0.0039,0.071]	[0.0029,0.063]	[0.021,0.073]	[0.039,0.088]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-500, 500]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.266	0.267	0.265	0.259
p-value	0.079	0.031	0.000	0.000
Observations	1945	2799	3521	3932
Panel C: Final Choices				
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.034*	0.032**	0.044***	0.065***
	(0.018)	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.012)
	[-0.00077,0.068]	[0.0039,0.059]	[0.020,0.069]	[0.043,0.088]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-500, 500]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.158	0.166	0.161	0.155
p-value	0.055	0.025	0.000	0.000
Observations	1759	2536	3198	3575

Notes: Each column reports the difference in labor supply between job offers above and below the husband's income within a given window. Columns (1), (2), (3), and (4) show estimates for offers within 500, 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively (as pre-registered). Panel A uses participants' *initial* job application choices, their choices the first time they are read the job descriptions; Panel B their *revised* job application choices, after a subset were informed that their choices would be shared with their husbands; and Panel C their *final* job application choices, after having time to discuss the jobs with their husband and family. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. The control mean is the proportion applying for jobs when the wage offer is at or below the husband's income. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.14: Difference in means test for breadwinning norms with and without controls.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Panel A: With Controls				
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.034*	0.032**	0.044***	0.065***
	(0.018)	(0.014)	(0.012)	(0.012)
	[-0.00077,0.068]	[0.0039,0.059]	[0.020,0.069]	[0.043,0.088]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-500, 500]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.158	0.166	0.161	0.155
p-value	0.055	0.025	0.000	0.000
Observations	1759	2536	3198	3575
Panel B: Without Controls				
Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.031*	0.031**	0.051***	0.069***
	(0.018)	(0.015)	(0.014)	(0.013)
	[-0.0043,0.067]	[0.00092,0.061]	[0.024,0.078]	[0.043,0.095]
Controls	No	No	No	No
Bandwidth	[-500, 500]	[-1000, 1000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-3000, 3000]
Control mean	0.157	0.166	0.161	0.155
p-value	0.085	0.043	0.000	0.000
Observations	1759	2536	3198	3575

Notes: Each column reports the difference in labor supply between job offers above and below the husband's income within a given window. Columns (1), (2), (3), and (4) show estimates for offers within 500, 1000, 2000, and 3000 rupees above or below the husband's income respectively (as pre-registered). In Panel A, we include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls, as in our main specification. In Panel B, we do not include fixed effects or controls. The control mean is the proportion applying for jobs when the wage offer is at or below the husband's income. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.15: Change in slope test for breadwinning norms at each decision stage.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: Initial Choices			
Offer relative to husband's wage	1.077	0.305	0.317**
	(0.667)	(0.313)	(0.157)
	[-0.23,2.38]	[-0.31,0.92]	[0.0097,0.62]
Offer relative to husband's wage			
× Offer above husband's wage (=1)	-1.221	0.060	0.142
	(1.191)	(0.554)	(0.274)
	[-3.56,1.12]	[-1.03,1.15]	[-0.40,0.68]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value (slope change)	0.306	0.914	0.604
Observations	2264	3168	3723
Panel B: Revised Choices			
Offer relative to husband's wage	1.207*	0.317	0.293*
	(0.656)	(0.310)	(0.156)
	[-0.080,2.49]	[-0.29,0.92]	[-0.013,0.60]
Offer relative to husband's wage			
× Offer above husband's wage (=1)	-1.564	0.032	0.199
	(1.176)	(0.551)	(0.273)
	[-3.87,0.74]	[-1.05,1.11]	[-0.33,0.73]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value (slope change)	0.184	0.953	0.465
Observations	2264	3168	3723
Panel C: Final Choices			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.638	-0.197	0.304**
	(0.607)	(0.291)	(0.136)
	[-0.55,1.83]	[-0.77,0.37]	[0.037,0.57]
Offer relative to husband's wage			
× Offer above husband's wage (=1)	-0.026	0.880*	0.130
	(1.106)	(0.514)	(0.239)
	[-2.20,2.14]	[-0.13,1.89]	[-0.34,0.60]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value (slope change)	0.981	0.087	0.587
Observations	2060	2880	3385

Notes: Each column tests for a change in the slope of labor supply at the husband's income by fitting a continuous piecewise-linear function (which allows for a change in slope at the husband's income). The relative wage offer is measured in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$). The first row reports the slope below the husband's income, and the second (the relative wage offer interacted with an indicator for the offer exceeding the husband's income) the change in slope above it. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. Panel A uses participants' *initial* job application choices, their choices the first time they are read the job descriptions; Panel B their *revised* job application choices, after a subset were informed that their choices would be shared with their husbands; and Panel C their *final* job application choices, after having time to discuss the jobs with their husband and family. All specifications include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), and confidence intervals (in brackets). The reported p-value refers to the change in slope coefficient. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.16: Change in slope test for breadwinning norms with and without controls.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Panel A: With Controls			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.638	-0.197	0.304**
	(0.607)	(0.291)	(0.136)
	[-0.55,1.83]	[-0.77,0.37]	[0.037,0.57]
Offer relative to husband's wage			
× Offer above husband's wage (=1)	-0.026	0.880*	0.130
	(1.106)	(0.514)	(0.239)
	[-2.20,2.14]	[-0.13,1.89]	[-0.34,0.60]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value (slope change)	0.981	0.087	0.587
Observations	2060	2880	3385
Panel B: Without Controls			
Offer relative to husband's wage	0.456	0.272	0.530***
	(0.649)	(0.321)	(0.144)
	[-0.82,1.73]	[-0.36,0.90]	[0.25,0.81]
Offer relative to husband's wage			
× Offer above husband's wage (=1)	0.076	0.267	-0.269
	(1.175)	(0.575)	(0.268)
	[-2.23,2.38]	[-0.86,1.40]	[-0.79,0.26]
Controls	No	No	No
Bandwidth	[0.95, 1.05]	[0.90, 1.10]	[0.80, 1.20]
p-value (slope change)	0.948	0.642	0.315
Observations	2060	2880	3385

Notes: Each column tests for a change in the slope of labor supply at the husband's income by fitting a continuous piecewise-linear function (which allows for a change in slope at the husband's income). The relative wage offer is measured in percentage terms ($\frac{\text{Unrounded wage offer}}{\text{Husband's income}}$). The first row reports the slope below the husband's income, and the second (the relative wage offer interacted with an indicator for the offer exceeding the husband's income) the change in slope above it. Columns (1), (2), and (3) show estimates for job offers within 5%, 10%, and 20% of the husband's income respectively. In Panel A, we include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls, as in our main specification. In Panel B, we do not include controls or fixed effects. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), and confidence intervals (in brackets). The reported p-value refers to the change in slope coefficient. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.17: Correlates of individual labor supply slopes.

	Dependent variable: Labor supply slope
	(1)
Has children (=1)	-0.084
	(0.111)
Number of children	-0.028
	(0.064)
Log husband's income	-0.043
	(0.081)
Ever worked (=1)	0.081
	(0.092)
Worked since marriage (=1)	-0.013
	(0.087)
Currently employed (=1)	0.236**
	(0.107)
Conservatism index (std.)	0.033
	(0.032)
Age	-0.004
	(0.009)
Years married	-0.003
	(0.009)
Finished college (=1)	0.018
	(0.070)
Husband finished college (=1)	-0.020
	(0.086)
Hindu (=1)	0.030
	(0.091)
Lives with in-laws (=1)	-0.063
	(0.090)
Observations	147

Notes: The dependent variable is a person-specific slope of inverse labor supply: for each participant, we regress an indicator for applying to a job on the log of the wage offer. In column (1), we regress the dependent variable on all listed characteristics. A larger coefficient indicates a given group is *more* responsive to changes in wages. We display the estimate and robust standard error (in parentheses). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.18: Balance table for spousal communication treatment.

	(1) Not sent to husband	(2) Sent to husband	(3) p-value	
Age	27.01	27.40	0.712	
Hindu	0.90	0.92	0.740	
Finished college	0.46	0.56	0.297	
Husband finished college	0.33	0.38	0.647	
Has children	0.58	0.67	0.342	
Lives with in-laws	0.78	0.75	0.686	
Employed	0.22	0.17	0.493	
Prop. jobs applied to (initial)	0.34	0.27	0.037	**
F-test: statistic			0.92	
F-test: p-value			0.51	
Number of observations	69	48		

Notes: Columns (1) and (2) report the group means in the two treatment arms. Column (3) shows the p-value for a test of equality between columns (1) and (2) using robust standard errors. We display the test statistic and p-value for an F-test for whether the covariates jointly predict treatment assignment. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.19: Impact of spousal communication treatment on decision making and job applications.

	Discussed job opportunities with family		Applied for job (=1)			
	(1) Discussed jobs	(2) Discussed all jobs	(3) Revised	(4) Revised	(5) Final	(6) Final
Applications sent to husband (=1)	-0.014	0.035	-0.063*	0.002	-0.042	0.003
	(0.040)	(0.089)	(0.034)	(0.003)	(0.029)	(0.020)
	[-0.093,0.064]	[-0.14,0.21]	[-0.13,0.0051]	[-0.0043,0.0090]	[-0.10,0.016]	[-0.037,0.043]
Controls	No	No	No	Yes	No	Yes
Control mean	0.968	0.710	0.331	0.331	0.199	0.199
p-value	0.719	0.699	0.069	0.486	0.155	0.868
Observations	105	105	3680	3680	3300	3300

Notes: Each column regresses the dependent variable on being randomly assigned to the spousal communication treatment, in which husbands were sent their wives' job application choices and where women were encouraged to discuss their choices with their family. In column (1) the dependent variable is an indicator for participants discussing their job applications with their family; in column (2) an indicator for discussing all their job applications with their family one by one; in columns (3) and (4) an indicator for applying for a job in the *revised* stage, immediately after being told their treatment status; and in columns (5) and (6) an indicator for applying for a job in the *final* stage, after having time to discuss with their husband and family. Columns (4) and (6) control for baseline variables including age, religion, education, husband's education, having children, living with in-laws, and employment, and the proportion of jobs they *initially* applied to (before learning their treatment status). We display the estimates, standard errors clustered at the individual level (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.20: Breadwinning norms test by spousal communication treatment assignment.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)			
	Choices not sent to husband		Choices sent to husband	
	(1) Initial	(2) Final	(3) Initial	(4) Final
RD Estimate	0.039	-0.007	-0.047	-0.019
	(0.034)	(0.028)	(0.037)	(0.033)
	[-0.028,0.10]	[-0.062,0.047]	[-0.12,0.025]	[-0.083,0.045]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.256	0.790	0.203	0.553
Observations	1293	1293	882	882

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply, using our pre-registered main specification: a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights and a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees on either side of the cutoff, dropping households where the husband's wage is less than 4,000 rupees, with individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job as controls. Columns (1)–(2) restrict to participants randomly assigned to the control group where their choices were not sent to their husbands; columns (3)–(4) to participants assigned to the treatment group where their choices were also sent to their husbands, and where participants were encouraged to discuss their choices with their family. Columns (1) and (3) use their *initial* choices, elicited before participants knew their treatment status; columns (2) and (4) use their *final* choices, elicited after choices were sent to their husbands and after having time to discuss with their family. All columns restrict to participants who completed the second survey, to compare across the same participants. Participants whose husbands did not provide a unique phone number were not included in this randomization. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.21: Test for breadwinning norms by working hours of the job.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)				
	Full sample	8-hour	10-hour	12-hour	24-hour
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
RD Estimate	0.004	0.022	-0.024	-0.008	-0.023
	(0.019)	(0.045)	(0.055)	(0.023)	(0.015)
	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.067,0.11]	[-0.13,0.083]	[-0.053,0.038]	[-0.052,0.0058]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.818	0.628	0.659	0.746	0.117
Observations	3198	687	349	1641	521

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply. The running variable is the difference between the wage offer and the husband's monthly income in levels (Wage offer − Husband's income). We estimate local linear regressions with triangular kernel weights, using our main specification: a bandwidth of 2000 rupees above or below the husband's income, dropping households where the husband's wage is less than 4000 rupees (as pre-registered). Column (1) uses the full main sample. Columns (2)–(5) restrict to job offers whose advertisement lists working hours of 8, 10, 12, and 24 hours respectively. The 24 hour jobs are live-in roles which are sometimes offered in the healthcare sector. In all specifications, we include individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job controls, and weight observations by the pre-registered inverse probability weights. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.22: Labor supply elasticities with respect to job attributes.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)	
	(1)	(2)
Log wages	0.329***	0.265***
	(0.026)	(0.028)
	[0.28,0.38]	[0.21,0.32]
Log wage × Wages important (=1)		0.177***
		(0.042)
		[0.095,0.26]
Log distance	-0.107***	-0.044**
	(0.010)	(0.020)
	[-0.13,-0.087]	[-0.084,-0.0046]
Log distance × Location important (=1)		-0.092***
		(0.024)
		[-0.14,-0.045]
12-24 hour shift (=1)	-0.174***	-0.146***
	(0.019)	(0.022)
	[-0.21,-0.14]	[-0.19,-0.10]
12-24 hour shift (=1) × Hours important (=1)		-0.054**
		(0.026)
		[-0.11,-0.0022]
Benefits offered (=1)	0.081***	0.061***
	(0.016)	(0.017)
	[0.049,0.11]	[0.028,0.094]
Benefits offered (=1) × Benefits important (=1)		0.045**
		(0.023)
		[0.00085,0.090]
Hospital position (=1)	0.152***	0.120***
	(0.017)	(0.017)
	[0.12,0.19]	[0.085,0.15]
Hospital position (=1) × Position important (=1)		0.126***
		(0.022)
		[0.082,0.17]
Individual FE	Yes	Yes
Dep. var. mean	0.191	0.190
Observations	4834	4614

Notes: Column (1) regresses job applications on log wages, log distance, a dummy for jobs with 12-24 hour shifts, a dummy for jobs with benefits, and a dummy for hospital jobs (as opposed to jobs in home care), with individual fixed effects. In Column (2) we interact these coefficients with whether a participant stated (after finalizing their application choices) that a given attribute was an important consideration to them. Standard errors clustered at the job level are shown in parentheses, confidence intervals in brackets. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.23: Test for breadwinning norms by work experience.

	Dependent variable: Applied for job (=1)			
	Full sample (1)	Ever worked (2)	Worked since marriage (3)	Currently working (4)
RD Estimate	0.004	0.007	-0.022	-0.011
	(0.019)	(0.021)	(0.026)	(0.034)
	[-0.033,0.042]	[-0.034,0.049]	[-0.073,0.028]	[-0.077,0.054]
Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]	[-2000, 2000]
p-value	0.818	0.725	0.387	0.733
Observations	3198	2436	1603	578

Notes: Each column reports an RD estimate of the effect of the wage offer exceeding the husband's income on labor supply, estimated on nested subsamples by work experience, using our pre-registered main specification: a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights and a bandwidth of 2,000 rupees on either side of the cutoff, dropping households where the husband's wage is less than 4,000 rupees, with individual fixed effects, job fixed effects, and distance to the job as controls. Column (1) uses the full sample; column (2) restricts to women who have ever worked; column (3) to women who have worked since marriage; and column (4) to women currently working. We display the estimates, robust standard errors (in parentheses), confidence intervals (in brackets), and p-values (below). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Table A.24: Largest mass points in the wife's share of couple earnings.

Wife's share of couple earnings	Percent (%)
0.500	4.33
0.333	2.98
0.400	2.08
0.250	1.66
0.375	1.63
0.286	1.57
0.444	1.49
0.429	1.47
0.200	1.38
0.167	1.31

Notes: The table lists the ten most common exact values of the wife's share of couple earnings ($\frac{\text{wife earnings}}{\text{husband earnings + wife earnings}}$) across India, using data from the PLFS between 2021 and 2024, for couples where both spouses have positive earnings ($N = 56{,}758$).

C Supplementary Material

C.1 CPHS Data

We use the Consumer Pyramids Household Survey (CPHS) from April 2015 to April 2025. CPHS visits each household every four months and records each member's monthly income and their employment status on the day of the visit. We form couples from each household head and their spouse, keeping households with exactly one head and one spouse, and follow each couple across visits using CPHS member identifiers. For each visit, we use each spouse's wage income in the month before the visit, so each couple contributes one observation per visit. The outcome is whether the wife is employed at the visit 12 months later, 13 months after the income month. We keep observations where the household completed both interviews and both spouses are still household members and coded as head and spouse at the later visit.

C.2 PLFS Data

We use the Periodic Labor Force Survey (PLFS) from July 2021 to June 2024. Each household can be visited multiple times, but only in urban areas, so only the first visit to a household is used. We form couples from each household head and their spouse, and from each married child of the head and their spouse, and keep couples in which both spouses report positive earnings. PLFS records each person's relationship to the household head, not to other members, so couples are read off the household roster. Two kinds of couple can be identified without ambiguity: the head and the head's spouse, and married children of the head and their spouses. A married child and their spouse appear in consecutive rows. Married people in any other relationship to the head (siblings, parents, other relatives, non-relatives) cannot be paired and are excluded. To harmonize earnings across participants, we annualize each spouse's earnings according to their activity status in the week before the survey: for regular salaried workers, earnings in the preceding calendar month, multiplied

by 12; for casual wage laborers, including MGNREGS workers, wages earned on each day of the reference week, multiplied by 52; and for self-employed own-account workers and employers, gross earnings over the last 30 days, multiplied by 12. Unpaid helpers in household enterprises and those who did not work during the reference week have no earnings. The wife's share of couple earnings is $\frac{\text{wife earnings}}{\text{husband earnings + wife earnings}}$.

C.3 Survey Instrument

DEMOGRAPHIC SCREENING

first_name

Whats is your first name?

last_name

What is your last name?

age

How old are you?

city

In which city/village do you currently reside?

neighborhood

In which neighborhood/area do you currently reside?

religion

Which religion do you follow?

Hindu
Muslim
Christian
Sikh
Jain
Buddhist
Do not belong to a denomination
Other (specify) _____

marital

What is your marital status?

Single
Widowed
Separated
Divorced
Live-in relationship with partner (not married)
Married

[If marital = Married]
living_husband

Do you currently live with your husband?

Yes, I am living with my husband
No, I am not living with my husband

[If living_husband = No]
husband_often

How often do you speak with your husband?

More than daily
Daily
A few times a week
Weekly
Monthly
Less than once a month

HUSBAND SCREENING

living_with_inlaws

Do you currently live with your in-laws?

Yes, I am living with my in-laws
No, I am not living with my in-laws

husband_contact

We need to ask your husband a few questions. Could you ask your husband to join us on the phone/conference call? Could you put the call on speakerphone so we can all speak? Please stay near your phone while we ask questions to your husband so that we can all hear each other.

Husband is there; phone is on speakerphone
Husband is on conference call

h_consent

Husband Consent Form

h_education

What is your highest level of education attained?

He has not completed primary school
He has completed primary school/5th grade
He has completed 10th grade
He has completed 12th grade
Currently enrolled in diploma/certificate course
Completed diploma/certificate course
He is currently studying undergraduate (Bachelor degree)
He has completed an undergraduate degree (Bachelor degree)
He is currently studying postgraduate (Masters or PhD degree)
He has completed a postgraduate degree (Masters or PhD degree)

h_age

What is your age?

h_employment

Do you currently have any job?

Yes, he has full-time paid employment (30 hours a week or more)
Yes, he has part time paid employment (less than 30 hours a week)
Yes, he has other self-employed work
No, he has no other paid employment but is seeking additional work
No, he has no other paid employment and is not seeking any additional work

[If h_employment = Yes]
h_occupation

What is your occupation? If you work multiple jobs, please list these.

HUSBAND INCOME

[If h_employment = Yes]
h_h_salary_type

What is your total monthly salary in INR(₹) ?

They provided a single number for the salary
They provided a salary range
They refused to provide a number

[If h_h_salary_type != Refused]
h_h_salary_take_home

Can we just confirm that this is your in-hand salary? Survey team: If they say no, please go back and ask them what their in-hand salary is

[If h_h_salary_type = They provided a single number for the salary]
h_h_salary_single

Record the salary

[If h_h_salary_type = They provided a single number for the salary]
h_h_salary_single2

Record the salary again to confirm.

[If h_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
h_h_salary_range

Lower bound of salary range
Upper bound of salary range

[If h_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
h_h_salary_range2

Confirm lower bound of salary range
Confirm upper bound of salary range

[If h_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
h_h_salary_range_av

We require one number for your salary, what is your average monthly salary?

[If h_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
h_h_salary_range_av2

Record the salary again to confirm.

[If h_employment = Yes]
h_h_salary_fixed

Is your salary the same each month or does it change from month to month?

Yes, his total salary is the same each month
No, his total salary changes from month to month

h_whatsapp

What is your WhatsApp number?

WIFE INCOME

education

What is the highest educational level that you have attained?

Have not completed primary school
Completed primary school/5th grade
Completed 10th grade
Completed 12th grade
Currently enrolled in diploma/certificate course
Completed diploma/certificate course
Currently studying undergraduate (Bachelor degree)
Completed an undergraduate degree (Bachelor degree)
Currently studying postgraduate (Masters or PhD degree
Completed a postgraduate degree (Masters or PhD degree)

employment

Do you currently have any job?

Yes, full-time paid employment (30 hours a week or more)
Yes, part time paid employment (less than 30 hours a week)
Yes, I have other self employed work
No, I have no other paid employment but am seeking additional work
No, I have no other paid employment and am not seeking any additional work

[If employment = Yes]
occupation

What is your occupation? If you work multiple jobs, please list these.

[If employment = Yes]
w_w_salary_type

What is your total monthly salary in INR(₹) ?

They provided a single number for the salary
They provided a salary range
They refused to provide a number

[If w_w_salary_type = They provided a single number for the salary]
w_w_salary_single

Record the salary

[If w_w_salary_type = They provided a single number for the salary]
w_w_salary_single2

Record the salary again to confirm.

[If w_w_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
w_w_salary_range

Lower bound of salary range
Upper bound of salary range

[If w_w_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
w_w_salary_range2

Confirm lower bound of salary range
Confirm upper bound of salary range

[If w_w_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
w_w_salary_ave

We require one number for your salary, what is your **average** monthly salary?

[If employment = Yes]
w_w_salary_fixed

Is your salary the same each month or does it change from month to month?

Yes, her total salary is the same each month
No, her total salary changes from month to month

HUSBAND INCOME CONFIRM

w_h_salary_type

Could you remind us what your husband's average monthly salary is?

They provided a single number for the salary
They provided a salary range
They refused to provide a number or don't know

[If w_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
w_h_salary_range

Lower bound of salary range
Upper bound of salary range

[If w_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
w_h_salary_range_av

Thanks, we require one number for salary, can you remind us what his monthly salary is on average?

[If w_h_salary_type = They provided a salary range]
w_h_salary_range_av2

Record the salary again to confirm.

[If w_h_salary_type = They provided a single number for the salary]
w_h_salary_single

Record the salary

[If w_h_salary_type = They provided a single number for the salary]
w_h_salary_single2

Record the salary again to confirm

w_h_salary_checked

Survey Team: Did she go and check with her husband before answering the question above?

No, she answered the question from memory.
Yes, she checked with him before answering.

HUSBAND INCOME RE-CONFIRM

[If w_h_salary_checked = No & wife's report != husband's report]
w_h_salary_discrep

It looks like he told us that his average monthly salary was [husband's reported amount]. You said [wife's reported amount]. Could you go check which it is with him? Survey team: If she chooses one without checking, record that number. If she checks but still does not have a clear answer, ask her which it is again. Record a single number below.

children

How many children do you have?

INTERESTED IN JOBS

interested_jobs

We have some job opportunities available which we have found through our Pratham placement team. Would you be interested in applying for any of these job opportunities? You will receive a payment/phone recharge of up to 500 INR for your time.

Yes, I am interested
No, I am not interested

HYPOTHETICAL DISCLAIMER - WOMEN

Placement Opportunities

Pratham is offering post-placement opportunities to trainees who have graduated from the program. I will now tell you about different job opportunities one at a time, and will ask you which jobs you would be interested in applying for. Some of the job ads are similar to the types of job opportunities we hope to secure, and some of the job ads are job opportunities we have already secured. All salaries are non-negotiable, irrespective of prior experience and additional certification or qualifications unless otherwise specified.

Unfortunately, there are more applicants than available jobs so we cannot offer you every job. Instead, at the end of the week, we will take the list of available jobs that we read to you, and randomly select one of them.

- If you told us that you were interested in this job, Pratham will reach out to you and try their best to place you into the job.
- If you told us you were not interested in this job, Pratham will not consider you for the job

The important thing to remember is that it is in your interest to simply consider each job opportunity on its own, and to honestly tell us whether you would be interested in applying for it.

You will also receive a phone recharge or UPI payment for participating in this survey. The payment will initially start at ₹500. However, if you are selected for one of the jobs you expressed interest in, you will be charged a processing fee of ₹150 and so will only receive a ₹350 voucher. For example, if you indicate you are interested in 10 jobs but are not selected for any of them you will still receive ₹500. If however, you are placed into one of these jobs you will only receive ₹350. Therefore, please consider each job advertisement carefully, and simply express your interests as honestly as possible. You can say yes or no to as many jobs as you would like. After this initial phone survey, we will give you a few days to reconsider any of the jobs you applied for. Ok, I am now going to start reading the job description. The salary I will read for each job refers to the in-hand salary.

JOB OFFERS

Read out all 40 job offers to the participant

Job1

Do you want to apply for the following job?
Job Number: 00670
Hospital Nursing Assistant
Ravindra Nagar, Indore
Salary: ₹8,000 per month (This salary is fixed and cannot be changed)
Working Hours: 8 hours
Benefits: None

Yes, I want to apply for this job
No, I do not want to apply for this job

Repeat for all 40 jobs

FOLLOW-UP

[If spousal communication = 1]
follow_up_time_share

Thank you for taking the time to complete this first survey. As mentioned, we will call you in 2-3 days to find out which job opportunities you are still interested in after discussing with your family. Could you let us know the best time to contact you when you will be free?

[If spousal communication = 0]
follow_up_time_no_sh

Thank you for taking the time to complete this first survey. As mentioned, we will call you in 2-3 days to find out which job opportunities you are still interested in. Could you let us know the best time to contact you when you will be free?

Q331

I will now send you a WhatsApp message with the jobs you have applied for. These are the jobs you expressed interest in. We will now give you a few days to consider the job opportunities more carefully. All salaries are non-negotiable, irrespective of prior experience and additional certification or qualifications unless otherwise specified. Remember that if you get selected for the job you are applying for, the voucher you get at the end of the survey will be reduced from Rs 500 to Rs 350.

[If spousal communication = 1]
drop_jobs_wa_share

We will now give you a few days to consider the jobs opportunities more carefully and to discuss them with your family. We will also WhatsApp the jobs you said you were interested in to your husband. Remember if you are selected for a job you apply for, it will reduce the voucher you get at the end of the survey by 150 INR.

Before we go, can you take a minute to look over the jobs I sent to you on WhatsApp, are there any you would like to remove from the list right now? Once you've done this, we'll send your final selections to your husband.

Yes, I would like to remove jobs from the list
No, the list is fine as is

[If spousal communication = 0]
drop_jobs_wa_noshare

We will now give you a few days to consider the jobs opportunities more carefully. Remember if you are selected for a job you apply for, it will reduce the voucher you get at the end of the survey by 150 INR.

Before we go, can you take a minute to look over the jobs I sent to you on WhatsApp, are there any you would like to remove from the list right now?

Yes, I would like to remove jobs from the list
No, the list is fine as is

CONCLUSION

[If drop_jobs_wa_share = Yes | drop_jobs_wa_noshare = Yes]
job_drop

Please enter the jobs the participant is no longer interested in after the WhatsApp message was sent (i.e. record what is written in the "Survey 1 Paper Survey").

[If spousal communication = 1]
husband_uniqueid_tex

We will now give you a few days to consider the jobs opportunities more carefully and discuss them with your family. All salaries are non-negotiable, irrespective of prior experience and additional certification or qualifications unless otherwise specified. Remember that if you get selected for the job you are applying for, the voucher you get at the end of the survey will be reduced from Rs 500 to Rs 350.

[If spousal communication = 0]
sharing_uniqueid_tex

These are the jobs you expressed interest in. We will now give you a few days to consider the job opportunities more carefully. All salaries are non-negotiable, irrespective of prior experience and additional certification or qualifications unless otherwise specified. Remember that if you get selected for the job you are applying for, the voucher you get at the end of the survey will be reduced from Rs 500 to Rs 350.